

Online Appendix

Friends in Higher Places: Social Fit and University Choice

OA1. Definitions of Constructed Variables

Region: We generally ‘region’ to refer to the nine ITL 1 regions of England, unless otherwise specified. These are the largest statistical subdivisions of England: the North East, the North West, Yorkshire and the Humber, the West Midlands, the East Midlands, East of England, London, the South East, and the South West. For some analysis, we aggregate the regions into the North (including the North East, the North West, and Yorkshire and the Humber), the Midlands (West and East Midlands), the South (including the South East, the South West, and the East of England), and London.

Neighbourhood income: Our main measure of socioeconomic background is students’ decile of the Index of Multiple Deprivation, which is a composite measure of deprivation constructed by the UK government based on incomes, unemployment, education, health, housing, and environment. This measure is defined based on the Lower-Level Super Output Area (LSOA) of a student’s home residence; LSOAs are neighbourhoods with an average population of 1500, roughly equivalent to a US Census Block Group. As shorthand, we refer to students in the bottom 4 (most deprived) deciles of IMD as ‘low-income’ or ‘from low-income neighbourhoods’ throughout.

GCSE grade percentile: As described in section A, all English students complete GCSEs in Maths, English, and Science, as well as some optional subjects. For our primary measure of ability, we focus on the core subjects since these are not affected by selection into who takes the subject. Students receive letter grades (A* – G) in each GCSE subject they complete until 2017, after which the grading switched to a 9–1 numerical scale. The mapping between letter grades and number grades was not one-to-one. To create a comparable measure across time, we therefore convert grades in each core subject into a percentile within each year based on the distribution of grades in that subject across all students who complete GCSEs. We then take the mean of these percentiles for each student across their core subjects. In some cases, we use the subject-specific percentiles.

A-Level tariff points: We convert letter A-Level grades to a numerical score using the UCAS tariff points scheme: A* = 56, A = 48, B = 40, C = 32, D = 24, E = 16. We then take the total of these tariff points across the student’s subjects, restricting to the top 3 subjects for students who take more than 3 A-levels, for a score out of 168 (A*A*A*).

Distance to university: We observe the LSOA (see the neighbourhood income definition above) that each student lived in in each year of school, which provides a reasonably

precise location measure; LSOAs have a median area of 0.5km^2 and a mean area of 4.3km^2 . For universities, we directly observe the university's region but do not observe any more precise location. As a proxy for the university's location, we consider all students who attend that university and report that they live with their parents during term time (which generally means that they live near enough to the campus to commute regularly to the university, particularly since our sample period is pre-COVID so that remote lectures were less common). We then take the midpoint of these student locations, based on students' last observed LSOA while at school, and infer that this is the approximate location of the university. This is not an exact measure, but acts as a reasonable proxy; spot-checks produce roughly correct university locations.

Earnings: Our primary measure of earnings is the total earnings in pounds received in a tax year from an individual's primary employer, conditioned on receiving positive earnings. We exclude earnings from self-employment because these are only included for tax years after 2013, meaning that it would be impossible to consistently include self-employment earnings for the whole sample. We restrict to individuals with positive earnings recorded because the data does not generally let us distinguish between individuals with 0 earnings in a year, individuals who have no earnings from employment but positive self-employment earnings, and individuals who have positive earnings but did not work in the UK in the given tax year or do not appear in the tax data for some other reason. Where we report earnings age profiles including zero earners, we assume that anyone who is observed in the educational data in an appropriate cohort, but is not observed in the tax data in the year corresponding to that age, had earnings of 0. We do not observe hours worked, so annual earnings may reflect part-time work or employment spells lasting less than a full year, which is why mean earnings can be well below the annual equivalent of full-time minimum wage. Earnings are deflated to 2018 levels using CPIH (Consumer Prices Index including owner occupiers' housing costs). Conversions into US dollars are at the 2018 PPP exchange rate for household final consumption expenditures as reported by the OECD 'Annual Purchasing Power Parities and exchange rates' dataset, which is $\text{£}0.7811 = \$1.0000$.

OA2. Additional Institutional Details

Each of the four nations of the UK – England, Scotland, Wales, and Northern Ireland – has a somewhat different educational system. Our administrative data is drawn from English students, and all but one of the schools taking part in the RCT are in England (one school is in Wales), so we focus on institutional details for England below.

Students in both England and Wales are required to remain in education until age 18. At age 16, students complete General Certificate of Secondary Education (GCSE) qualifications in specific subjects. Students are required to complete GCSEs in English, Mathematics, and Science, and can take additional optional GCSEs depending on their preferences and the GCSEs offered by their school; the median student completes 8 GCSEs. Full-time education at ages 15–16 is focused on preparing students for GCSEs. After completing GCSEs, students must remain in education, but need not stay in full-time education. Academically oriented students typically remain in full-time education to complete GCE Advanced Level (A-Level) qualifications in specific subjects, but alternative routes include vocational qualifications (most commonly Business and Technology Education Council—BTEC—certificates), full-time apprenticeships, or part-time employment alongside part-time training. A-Level students pick a small number of subjects—typically 3–4—to study, again based on both their preferences and the subjects offered by their school. It is reasonably common to change schools after completing GCSEs to attend a dedicated ‘sixth form college’ or ‘further education college’ that offers only 16–18 education, but many schools also offer 11–18 education. Courses receive applications from students without observing the other universities that students apply to. Admissions decisions are generally made at the course level, rather than holistically by the university.

After students receive offers, they choose up to two offers to accept, one as a ‘firm choice’ (a student’s top choice that they plan to attend if they meet any offer conditions), and one as an ‘insurance choice’ (a course that will accept them if they fail to meet the conditions for their firm choice but achieve that course’s conditions; students thus generally select an insurance choice with more lenient conditions than the firm choice). Students then complete exams and coursework required for their A-Levels or other qualifications, and receive grades later in the year. Depending on the grades they may attend their firm choice or their insurance choice, or if they fail to meet the conditions for either offer they can enter the ‘Clearing’ process – an after-market ‘scramble’ facilitated by UCAS in which universities list remaining open course slots and students can put in new direct applications to these courses given their realised (rather than predicted) grades. If they choose not to enter this process or fail to find an available course as part of it, they are free to reapply in the

following year or not to attend university.

University tuition for domestic students is capped by the government. As almost all universities charge tuition at the cap, this means that there is no variation in tuition costs for students between universities. The government provides universal income-contingent loans covering all tuition costs to all students: under the current policy regime, students pay no tuition upfront and repay 9% of their annual income in excess of £25,000 after graduating. Interest rates are linked to inflation. Any debt remaining unpaid after 40 years is cancelled. Thresholds, repayment rates, and write-off periods have changed over time, but the essential income-contingent structure of loans has been in place since reforms to tuition fees in 2012. The government also provides maintenance loans to cover living expenses: the amount offered depends on parental income and whether students live with their parents, and there is a supplement for students living in London. These are paid back in the same way as tuition loans. Prior regimes

OA3. Supplemental Exhibits: Robustness Checks and Alternative Specifications

Table OA1: Application event studies for top 10 universities with ability controls

	(1) Apply	(2) Apply	(3) Apply	(4) Apply	(5) Apply	(6) Apply
$1\{t = -4\} \times 1\{\text{Treated}\}$	0.000708 (0.000378)	0.000831* (0.000376)	0.000545 (0.000398)	-0.000914 (0.000717)	-0.000391 (0.000711)	-0.000656 (0.000740)
$1\{t = -3\} \times 1\{\text{Treated}\}$	-0.000348 (0.000353)	-0.000344 (0.000358)	-0.000344 (0.000379)	-0.000903 (0.000700)	-0.000712 (0.000708)	-0.000921 (0.000739)
$1\{t = -2\} \times 1\{\text{Treated}\}$	-0.0000626 (0.000365)	-0.0000712 (0.000365)	-0.000253 (0.000383)	-0.000752 (0.000702)	-0.000844 (0.000696)	-0.00115 (0.000731)
$1\{t = -1\} \times 1\{\text{Treated}\}$	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
$1\{t = 0\} \times 1\{\text{Treated}\}$	0.00337*** (0.000377)	0.00284*** (0.000371)	0.00304*** (0.000392)	0.00361*** (0.000710)	0.00290*** (0.000700)	0.00277*** (0.000726)
$1\{t = 1\} \times 1\{\text{Treated}\}$	0.00489*** (0.000442)	0.00440*** (0.000427)	0.00431*** (0.000437)	0.00591*** (0.000783)	0.00504*** (0.000791)	0.00501*** (0.000807)
$1\{t = 2\} \times 1\{\text{Treated}\}$	0.00590*** (0.000473)	0.00554*** (0.000458)	0.00539*** (0.000465)	0.00661*** (0.000800)	0.00566*** (0.000819)	0.00567*** (0.000847)
$1\{t = 3\} \times 1\{\text{Treated}\}$	0.00505*** (0.000482)	0.00480*** (0.000474)	0.00479*** (0.000489)	0.00494*** (0.000913)	0.00375*** (0.000900)	0.00364*** (0.000929)
$1\{t = 4\} \times 1\{\text{Treated}\}$	0.00543*** (0.000523)	0.00541*** (0.000516)	0.00545*** (0.000526)	0.00510*** (0.000804)	0.00399*** (0.000812)	0.00363*** (0.000842)
N	8,133,835	8,080,870	7,284,345	1,969,650	1,962,180	1,812,640
Sample mean	0.0180	0.0178	0.0191	0.0126	0.0125	0.0131
Pre-treatment mean	0.0184	0.0184	0.0196	0.0108	0.0108	0.0114
GCSE controls	N	Y	Y	N	Y	Y
A-level controls	N	N	Y	N	N	Y
School-level matching	N	N	N	Y	Y	Y

Standard errors in parentheses.

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$.

Notes: Data: LEO. Coefficients from event studies of the effects of breakthroughs on applications to the breakthrough university using different sets of controls, pooled across top 10 universities. All regressions include school-by-breakthrough-university and year-by-breakthrough-university fixed effects. Column (2) includes GCSE percentile by breakthrough university effects; column (3) adds controls for the number of A-levels and the number of facilitating (more academic) A-levels completed; column (4) has no ability controls, but restricts to schools that are matched on 2007–2009 observables and includes match pair-by-year-by-breakthrough-university fixed effects; column (5) adds GCSE percentile by breakthrough university effects to the matched specification; column (6) adds controls for the number of A-levels and the number of facilitating (more academic) A-levels completed to this specification. 95% confidence intervals reported based on standard errors clustered at the school level.

Table OA2: Application event studies for top 10 universities by distance to the breakthrough university

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Region		Median dist.		Dist. (miles)	
	Different	Same	Below	Above	≤ 30	> 30
$1\{t = -4\} \times 1\{\text{Treated}\}$	-0.000353 (0.000754)	-0.00369 (0.00354)	0.000630 (0.00118)	-0.000818 (0.000930)	-0.000740 (0.00189)	-0.000390 (0.000794)
$1\{t = -3\} \times 1\{\text{Treated}\}$	-0.000622 (0.000738)	-0.00306 (0.00394)	0.0000477 (0.00113)	0.0000154 (0.00107)	0.000449 (0.00201)	-0.000479 (0.000840)
$1\{t = -2\} \times 1\{\text{Treated}\}$	-0.000901 (0.000730)	-0.0000121 (0.00474)	0.00147 (0.00126)	-0.00168 (0.00101)	0.000176 (0.00242)	-0.00110 (0.000814)
$1\{t = -1\} \times 1\{\text{Treated}\}$	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)	0 (0)
$1\{t = 0\} \times 1\{\text{Treated}\}$	0.00276*** (0.000741)	0.00626 (0.00405)	0.00459*** (0.00123)	0.00229* (0.00104)	0.00283 (0.00239)	0.00251** (0.000802)
$1\{t = 1\} \times 1\{\text{Treated}\}$	0.00496*** (0.000821)	0.00265 (0.00410)	0.00495*** (0.00130)	0.00520*** (0.00116)	0.00167 (0.00234)	0.00538*** (0.000948)
$1\{t = 2\} \times 1\{\text{Treated}\}$	0.00506*** (0.000856)	0.0153*** (0.00450)	0.00789*** (0.00135)	0.00297* (0.00124)	0.00790** (0.00251)	0.00390*** (0.000980)
$1\{t = 3\} \times 1\{\text{Treated}\}$	0.00331*** (0.000932)	0.00901 (0.00523)	0.00478*** (0.00142)	0.00167 (0.00135)	0.00290 (0.00284)	0.00306** (0.00108)
$1\{t = 4\} \times 1\{\text{Treated}\}$	0.00315*** (0.000828)	0.0116* (0.00569)	0.00461*** (0.00135)	0.00346** (0.00132)	0.00521 (0.00273)	0.00381*** (0.000983)
<i>N</i>	1,703,905	107,585	881,675	857,295	346,370	1,392,910
Sample mean	0.0125	0.0237	0.0148	0.0103	0.0164	0.0116
Pre-treat mean	0.0108	0.0203	0.0125	0.00883	0.0137	0.00998

Standard errors in parentheses.

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$.

Notes: Data: LEO. Coefficients from event studies of the effects of breakthroughs on applications to the breakthrough university for students with different distances to the breakthrough university, pooled across top 10 universities. All regressions include school-by-breakthrough-university and year-by-breakthrough-university fixed effects. Column (1) includes only students in a different (ITL 1) region from the breakthrough university, while column (2) includes only students in the same region as the breakthrough university. Column (3) restricts to students below the median distance from the breakthrough university (which is calculated separately for each breakthrough university), and column (4) to students above the median distance. Column (5) restricts to students within 30 miles of the breakthrough university, and column (6) to students located more than 30 miles from the breakthrough university. 95% confidence intervals reported based on standard errors clustered at the school level.

Table OA3: Robustness of breakthrough effects on applications

PLACEHOLDER Robustness of the breakthrough application effects: alternative ability controls, matched-school specifications, and alternative sample restrictions, pooled across breakthroughs to top 10 universities. Candidate table files are listed in the comment above this table.			
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Notes: Robustness of the effect of breakthroughs on applications to the breakthrough university, pooled across top 10 universities. All specifications include school-by-breakthrough-university and year-by-breakthrough-university fixed effects. Standard errors clustered at the school level.

Table OA4: Mean characteristics for compliers (students who apply in response to a breakthrough) and broader samples

Variable	(1) Complier mean	(2) Mean for enrollees at breakthrough universities	(3) Event study sample mean	(4) Event study treated schools mean
<i>Panel A: Breakthroughs to universities ranked 1–10</i>				
Female	0.460	0.482	0.576	0.571
White	0.707	0.803	0.809	0.81
Low-income	0.297	0.147	0.331	0.304
FSM eligible	0.188	0.057	0.147	0.135
Northern England	0.203	0.181	0.311	0.309
The Midlands	0.205	0.139	0.212	0.197
Southern England	0.318	0.472	0.332	0.337
GCSE percentile	88.4	92.3	68.4	70.8
≥ 3 A-levels	0.921	0.954	0.620	0.688

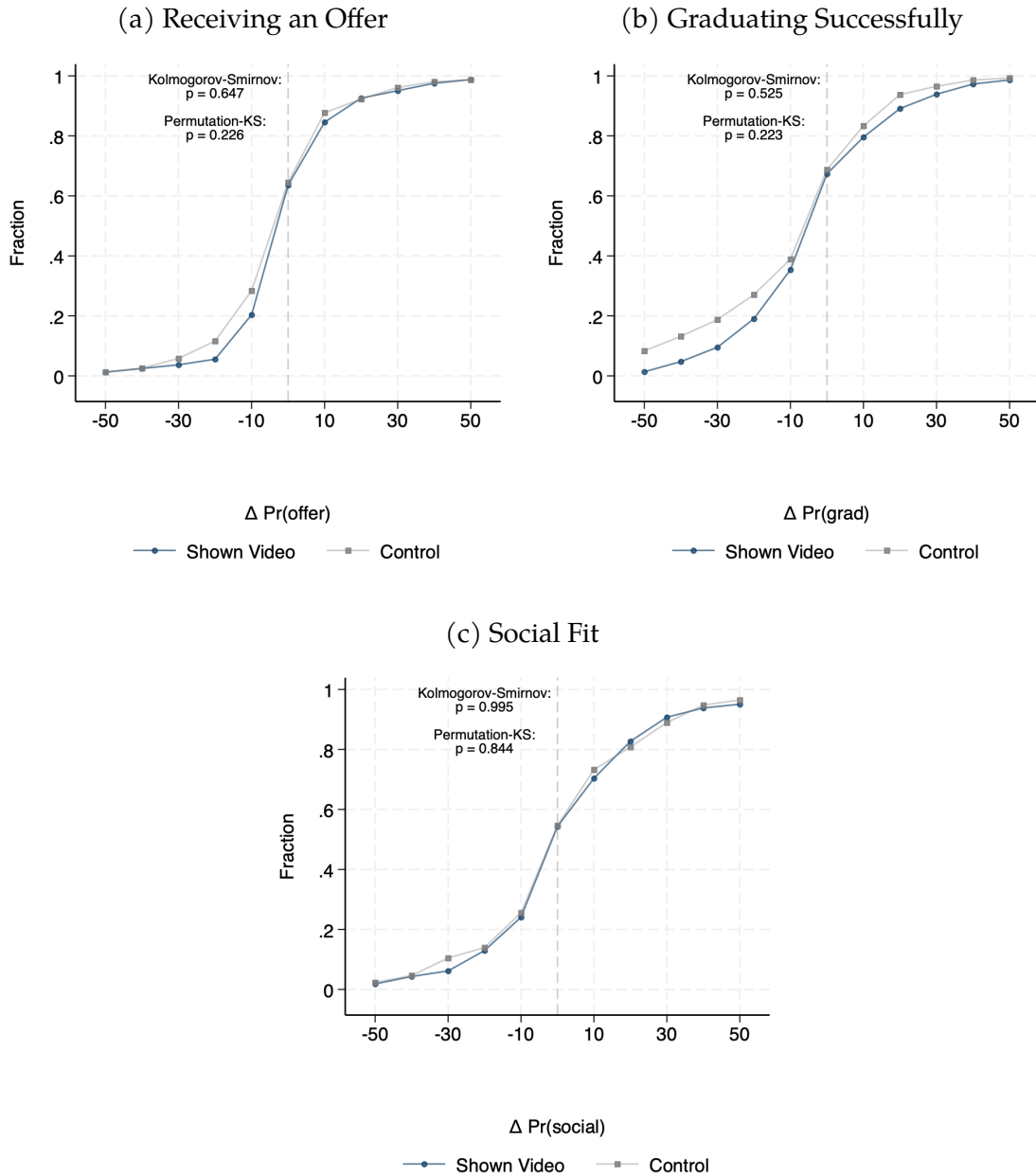
Notes: Comparison of mean characteristics for compliers – treating breakthroughs as an instrument for applications to the breakthrough university – with the population of all students who enroll at the breakthrough university (in column 2), for all students in the analysis sample for event studies (in column 3) and for all students at treated schools in the analysis sample (in column 4). Characteristics for compliers are estimated as in equation (??); other characteristics are raw means within the specified sample. ‘FSM eligible’ denotes eligibility for Free School Meals. ‘Low-income’ denotes students in the poorest two quintiles of our neighbourhood deprivation measure. GCSE percentiles are average percentiles of age-16 test scores estimated separately by year. Taking ≥ 3 A-levels is the standard qualification for academic-track students.

Table OA5: Belief updating about video university, by SES

	Positive Update		Negative Update		No Update		Δ Belief	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)
	Low-SES	High-SES	Low-SES	High-SES	Low-SES	High-SES	Low-SES	High-SES
<i>Panel A. Social fit</i>								
Video treatment	0.094*	-0.040	-0.138***	-0.031	0.044	0.071	4.801*	-0.234
	(0.054)	(0.066)	(0.050)	(0.058)	(0.051)	(0.063)	(2.751)	(3.244)
Control mean	0.36	0.43	0.36	0.27	0.28	0.30	2.12	4.09
N	329	224	329	224	329	224	329	224
<i>Panel B. Receive an offer</i>								
Video treatment	0.017	-0.023	-0.043	0.005	0.025	0.019	4.732*	-0.258
	(0.055)	(0.066)	(0.049)	(0.058)	(0.050)	(0.064)	(2.441)	(2.888)
Control mean	0.43	0.41	0.29	0.25	0.28	0.34	2.94	3.65
N	329	224	329	224	329	224	329	224
<i>Panel C. Graduate successfully</i>								
Video treatment	0.057	0.042	-0.025	-0.029	-0.031	-0.013	1.374	1.942
	(0.054)	(0.060)	(0.053)	(0.061)	(0.053)	(0.066)	(2.780)	(2.801)
Control mean	0.33	0.26	0.34	0.30	0.33	0.43	0.26	-1.39
N	312	224	312	224	312	224	312	224

Notes:

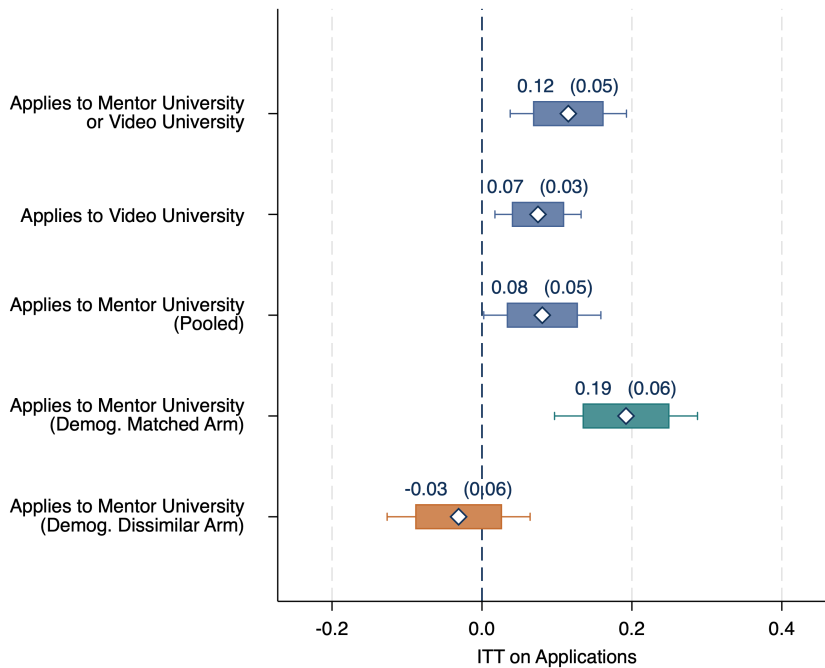
Figure OA1: Placebo treatment effects on university beliefs (Oxford), low-SES



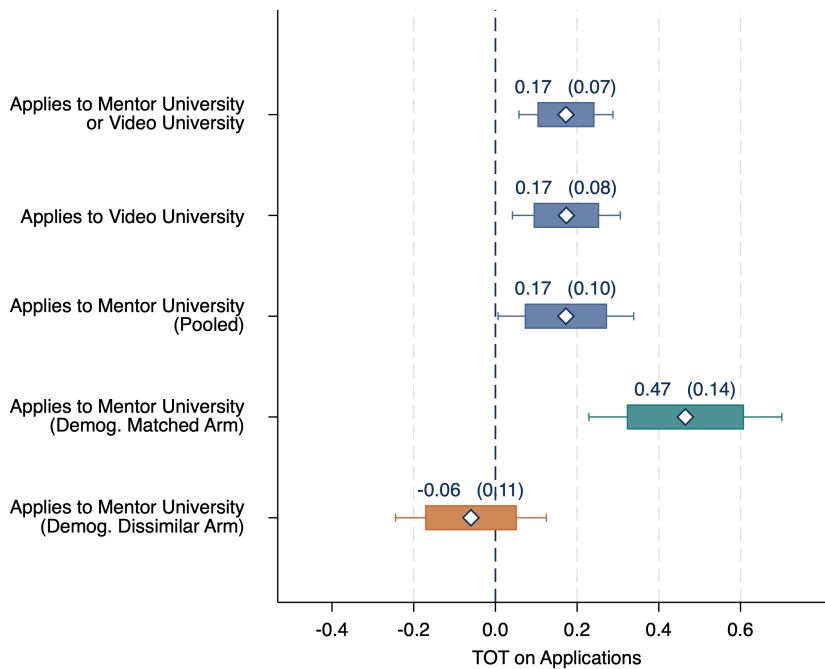
Notes: Data: RCT. Sample restricted to students who completed both baseline and midline surveys. Each panel plots the cumulative distribution of the percentage point change between the baseline and midline survey in the reported probability of the specified outcome at the student's assigned video university, separately for students who were and were not assigned to the video treatment arms. We pool across arms T1a, T1b, T2a and T2b. Each panel reports the p-value from a Kolmogorov-Smirnov test of equality of the two distributions. Elicited beliefs were restricted to be multiples of 10, so distributions are discrete; updates are truncated to between -40 and $+40$. Beliefs about social fit shift markedly in response to the video treatment, while beliefs about offer and graduation probabilities do not.

Figure OA2: Treatment effects on university applications

(a) ITT (pooled across SES)



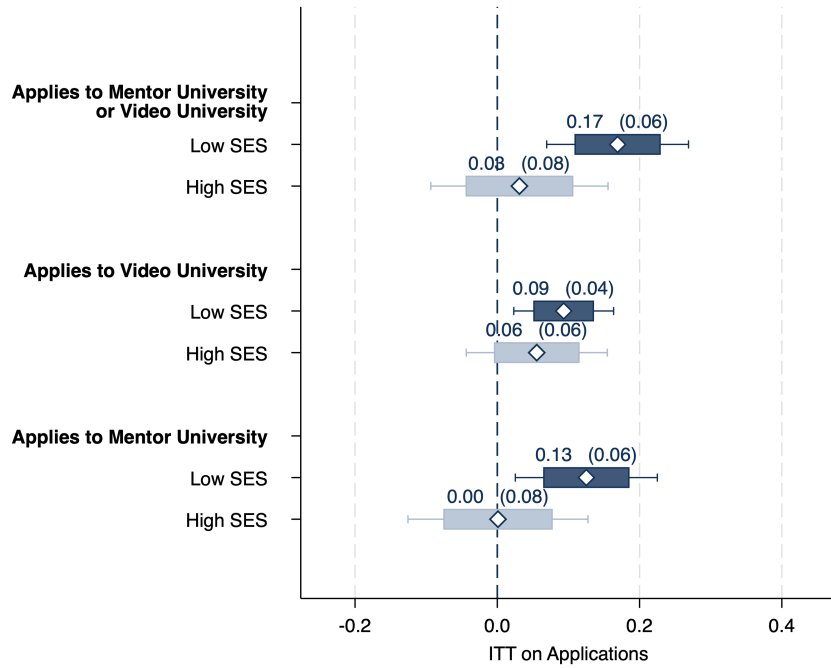
(b) TOT (pooled across SES)



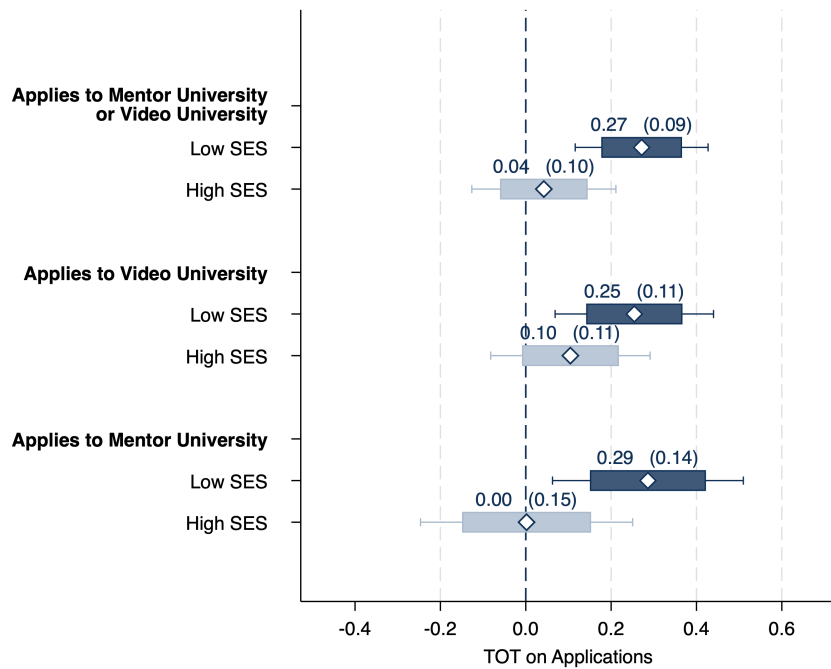
Notes: Includes students who said they are definitely not interested in mentors (and were therefore no longer part of the RCT).

Figure OA3: Treatment effects on university applications, by SES

(a) ITT (by SES)



(b) TOT (by SES)



Notes:

OA4. Effects of equalising application rates on socioeconomic enrollment gaps

Adapting a decomposition described by Chetty, Deming, and Friedman (2026) to our context, we observe that the probability of enrollment at a given university through the main UCAS application scheme can be decomposed as:

$$\begin{aligned} P(\text{enroll}) &= P(\text{apply}) \\ (OA1) \quad &\times P(\text{receive offer} \mid \text{apply}) \\ &\times P(\text{accept offer} \mid \text{receive offer}) \\ &\times P(\text{enroll} \mid \text{accept offer}) \end{aligned}$$

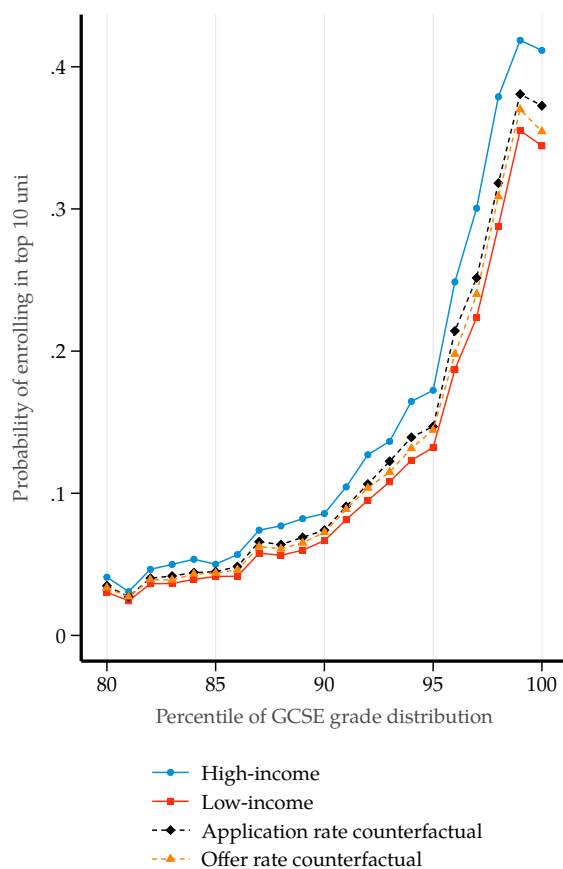
Focusing on students who enroll at university in the main scheme, we can thus decompose overall enrollment gaps (i.e., $P(\text{enroll} \mid \text{high income}) - P(\text{enroll} \mid \text{low income})$) into components explained by differences in application rates, offer rates, offer acceptance rates, and conditional enrollment rates. Taking logs of (OA1) produces an additive decomposition in terms of log points; we can also predict the enrollment rate for low-income students if they applied at the same rate as high-income students by taking

$$\begin{aligned} &P(\text{enroll} \mid \text{low income, high income application rate}) \\ &= P(\text{apply} \mid \text{high income}) \\ &\quad \times P(\text{receive offer} \mid \text{apply, low income}) \\ &\quad \times P(\text{accept offer} \mid \text{receive offer, low income}) \\ &\quad \times P(\text{enroll} \mid \text{accept offer, low income}) \end{aligned}$$

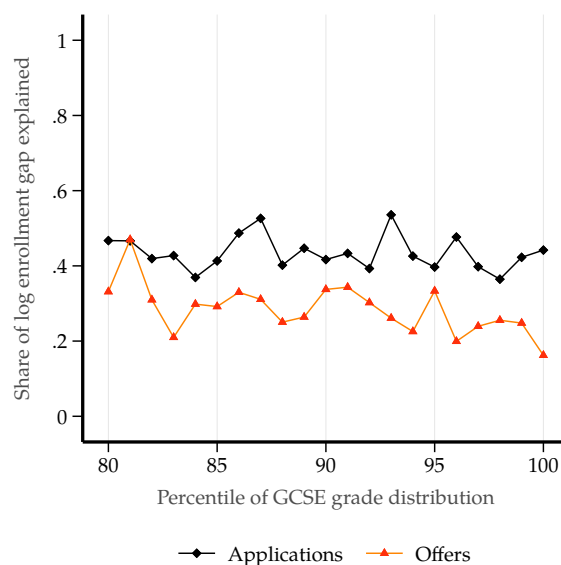
Estimating this decomposition reveals that disparities in applications explain a large fraction of overall disparities in enrollment. We estimate it conditional on students' ability, as measured by their percentile in the national GCSE distribution, focusing on the probability of enrollment in one of the top 10 universities. In the 90th–100th percentile of the GCSE distribution, where application and enrollment rates are highest, differences in application rates explain the largest share of differences in enrollment rates out of the four components of the decomposition; the share of enrollment differences explained by application differences averages around 40–50% and is consistently higher than that explained by offer differences. This is a higher share than found by Chetty, Deming, and Friedman in the context of Ivy-Plus enrollment gaps in the US, where only 30% of the differences in the excess enrollment of the top 1% could be attributed to application gaps, compared with 57% that could be explained by admissions.

Figure OA4: Decomposition of gaps in attendance at top 10 universities

(a) Actual and counterfactual enrollment rates



(b) Share of enrollment gap explained



Notes: Data: LEO. In panel (a), solid lines plot the probability of enrolling at one of the top 10 universities conditional on percentile in the national GCSE grade distribution (truncating at 80 since applications to top universities are very low below this rate), and conditional on enrolling through the main UCAS scheme. Application rate counterfactual calculated mechanically by multiplying application rate for high income students by offer rate, offer acceptance rate, and conditional enrollment rate for low-income students. Offer rate counterfactual similarly calculated by multiplying offer rate for high income students by application rate, offer acceptance rate, and conditional enrollment rate for low-income students. In panel (b), we take logs of the four components of the enrollment rate to get an additive decomposition, and plot the share attributable to applications and offers (i.e. the log difference in application rate and offer rate as a fraction of the log difference in enrollment rate).

OA5. Effects of equalising exposure rates on socioeconomic application disparities

We combine estimates of differences in exposure to students attending top universities between high-income and low-income students with our estimates of the treatment effects of breakthroughs. Taking the latter as the causal effect of inducing exposure to a university on applications, we can now conduct a simple back-of-the-envelope exercise to quantify the effect that equalising exposure across income groups would have on application rates. Specifically, let the exposure rates for low-income and high-income students to university u – specifically, the probability of low or high-income students attending a school where at least one student has attended that university in the last three years – be $e_u^l, e_u^h \in [0, 1]$ respectively, and let the treatment effect of exposure at university u , as estimated from the difference-in-difference coefficient in the breakthrough event studies, be Δ_u . Then we can predict

$$(OA2) \quad Pr(\text{apply}_u \mid l, e_u^h) = Pr(\text{apply}_u \mid l, e_u^l) + \Delta_u(e_u^h - e_u^l)$$

We pool GCSE grades into ventiles (since we are not powered to estimate treatment effects conditional on exact percentiles), and then estimate the difference-in-differences regression separately within each ventile of GCSE grades for university u to get a grade-dependent treatment effect, $\Delta_u(g)$. We then combine this with exposure rates similarly calculated by GCSE ventile, $e_u^h(g), e_u^l(g)$, to get

$$(OA3) \quad Pr(\text{apply}_u \mid g, l, e_u^h) = Pr(\text{apply}_u \mid g, l, e_u^l) + \Delta_u(g)(e_u^h(g) - e_u^l(g))$$

Finally, we sum these effects over each of the top 10 universities to get

$$(OA4) \quad Pr(\text{apply top 10} \mid g, l, e^h) = Pr(\text{apply top 10} \mid g, l, e^l) + \sum_{u \in \{1, \dots, 10\}} \Delta_u(g)(e_u^h(g) - e_u^l(g))$$

making use of the empirical result that breakthroughs to university u do not affect applications to any similarly ranked university u' to simplify the calculation.

OA6. Earnings effects of graduating from selective universities

From an economic perspective, the primary reason to care about access to elite universities is that the university a student attends is consequential for their labour market outcomes. Since our administrative data link university applications and attendance to earnings, test scores, and demographics for a very large sample of students, we can precisely estimate earnings for graduates of individual universities across the distribution of university selectivity. We use this to illustrate the potential returns to students going to a higher-ranked university. Throughout this analysis, as well as in the rest of the paper, we rank universities by the mean A-level grades of students who are enrolled at each university.

We first plot the age profile of earnings for graduates from different universities from 18–30, finding that the earnings of graduates overtake those of non-attendees or dropouts by around age 23. Our primary outcome in this analysis is annual earnings from an individual’s primary employer, conditional on receiving positive earnings in the tax year.⁴¹ Figure OA5a illustrates how mean annual earnings change over time for students with different university outcomes. University attendees earn less than non-attendees until age 22, but start to earn substantially more than non-attendees after this age. We also clearly see that graduating from a higher-ranked university is associated with higher earnings, and that the gaps between higher- and lower-ranked universities are larger than those between lower-ranked universities and non-attendees. By age 30, non-attendees at university have annual earnings around £20,000, graduates from an average university (below the top 30) have earnings around £26,000, and graduates from a top 10 university have earnings around £44,000. We also see from this figure that the relative earnings differentials have largely stabilised by age 27, suggesting that earnings at this age are a reasonable proxy for future earnings differences. This motivates our focus on earnings at age 27 as our primary measure of earnings in the remainder of this paper.⁴² The whole distribution of earnings at age 27 for top-10 graduates lies to the right of that for graduates of lower-ranked universities, not just the mean.

We next attempt to adjust for selection, now looking university-by-university at earnings effects. For student i who graduates from university u and is aged 27 in year t , we estimate

41. See appendix OA1 for an explanation of the precise earnings outcome used. Earnings age profiles that instead assign 0 earnings to individuals who do not appear in the tax data show the same pattern.

42. More precisely, since tax years and academic years are misaligned – tax years start in April while academic years start in September – we use earnings in the tax year starting 9 years after the student completed their high school education, meaning students born between April and August would be 26 at the start of the tax year while all other students would be 27.

the regression

$$(OA5) \quad Y_{itu} = \alpha + \beta X_i + \theta_u + \delta_t + \varepsilon_{itu}$$

where X_i is a vector of individual-level observables, θ_u is a university fixed effect, and δ_t a year fixed effect. The omitted university dummy is the modal university in the sample.

We plot the fixed effect for each university θ_u after applying empirical Bayes shrinkage to point estimates of the university effects. Specifically, let s_u be the estimated standard error of the coefficient θ_u and $\mu_\theta, \sigma_\theta^2$ be the mean and variance of the estimated θ_u coefficients across universities; then

$$(OA6) \quad \theta_u^* = \frac{\sigma_\theta^2}{\sigma_\theta^2 + s_u^2} \theta_u + \frac{s_u^2}{\sigma_\theta^2 + s_u^2} \mu_\theta$$

$$(OA7) \quad s_u^* = \sqrt{\frac{\sigma_\theta^2}{\sigma_\theta^2 + s_u^2}} s_u$$

While we cannot identify universities by name,⁴³ we plot earnings against each university's rank by the mean of the top 3 A-level grades, converted to UCAS tariff points (see Appendix OA1), achieved by students who enroll at the university. The modal (omitted) university is ranked 56, close to the median.

Figure OA5b plots the results of this analysis. Specification 1 includes no controls in X_i and thus reflects only the raw differences in earnings across universities after applying empirical Bayes shrinkage. Specification 2 controls for observables: demographics, test scores, and major. It also introduces fixed effects for the exact portfolio of universities that the student receives an offer from (a subset of those that they apply to). Offer portfolios proxy for unobserved components of ability. If we could assume that university choice conditional on an offer portfolio is independent of ability, as argued in Dale and Krueger (2002, 2014) and Mountjoy and Hickman (2021), these estimates could be interpreted as causal effects on earnings. However, this is a strong assumption in this context, so we instead interpret offer portfolios as another observable that can help us absorb more variation in ability.

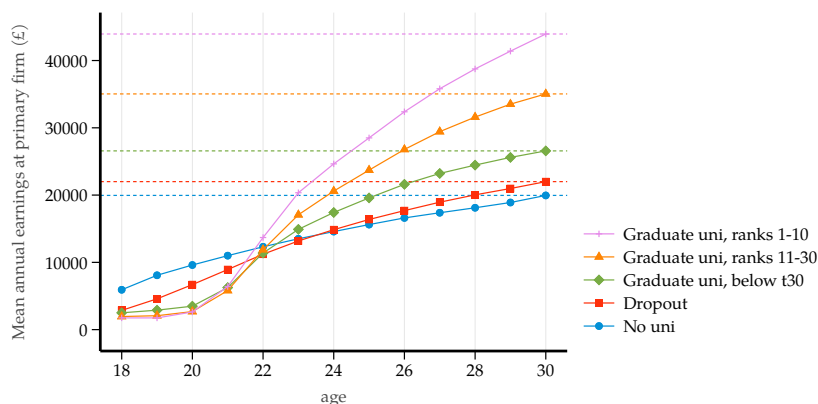
Figure OA5c plots the coefficients for each university from just this latter specification, to better illustrate the range of estimated earnings effects, and adds confidence intervals to the estimates. Points in black have estimates that are significantly different from the

43. See Britton et al. (2022) for analysis of the earnings returns to different universities in the UK that is able to name universities. Their analysis is conducted without data on applications and offers, so they are not able to include offer set controls in their specifications, but they find a similar pattern of high returns for the most selective universities and a flat selectivity-earnings gradient beyond these elite universities.

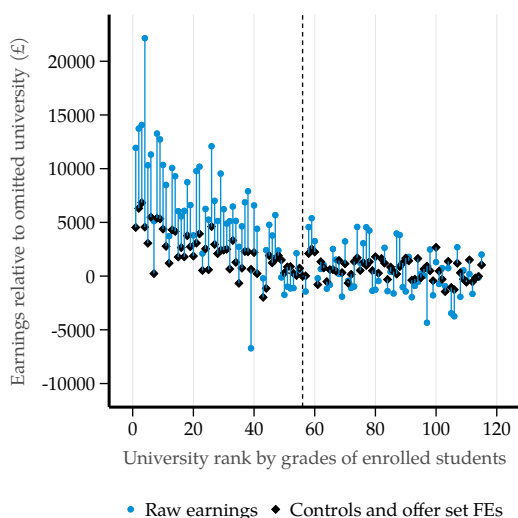
mean university fixed effect (relative to the omitted university) after shrinkage. We see that most of the top 10–20 universities have distinctly higher returns than the median university – the average coefficient for the top 10 universities, relative to the omitted university, is £4,614. This is much lower than the descriptive gaps in earnings, but still a substantial increase, corresponding to 24% of mean earnings for all individuals at age 27 and 18% of mean earnings for all university graduates. Outside top institutions, there is a flat gradient between selectivity and earnings effects, and most coefficients are not significantly different from the mean effect of £1,220. Access to the most selective universities is thus particularly important for students’ earning potential, and socioeconomic disparities in students’ access to these universities are likely to perpetuate income inequality.

Figure OA5: Earnings returns to universities at age 27 across the distribution of university academic selectivity

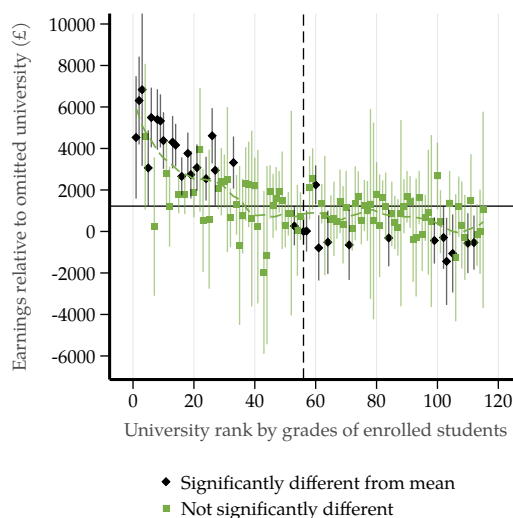
(a) Earnings trajectories by age



(b) Unconditional and conditional earnings effects



(c) Conditional earnings effects



Notes: Estimates of the earnings return to different universities. Data: LEO. All earnings are in GBP and adjusted to inflation in 2018. Panel (a) plots mean earnings conditional on age and university outcome, and on positive earnings. We restrict to students starting a degree at age 18 for dropouts and university graduates; dropouts are those who do not earn a degree within 8 years of completing high school, and graduates are those who earn a degree within 4 years of completing high school. Students completing a degree in 5–8 years are excluded. Panel (b) plots unconditional earnings gaps (in blue) and conditional earnings gaps (in green) between graduates of different universities. The unconditional gap records the coefficient on each university in a regression of earnings at age 27 on university fixed effects, omitting the university at rank 56, after applying empirical Bayes shrinkage to university effect estimates. Universities are ranked on the X-axis by the mean A-level tariff points of their enrolled students (see Appendix OA1). The conditional specification adds controls for gender, ethnicity, neighbourhood income decile, GCSE grades, A-level grades, major, and offer set to the regression. Panel (c) simply plots the conditional estimates shown in panel (b), rescaling the Y-axis and reporting 95% confidence intervals (based on standard errors after applying empirical Bayes shrinkage clustered at the high school level). Estimates that are significantly different from the mean at the 5% level are highlighted in black.

OA7. Supplemental Experimental Details

Table OA6: Balance table

	Sample means					Differences in means	
	All (1)	C (2)	T (3)	T1 (4)	T2 (5)	T-C (6)	T2-T1 (7)
<i>Panel A: demographics</i>							
Female	0.422 (0.020)	0.455 (0.027)	0.386 (0.028)	0.396 (0.040)	0.375 (0.039)	-0.069* (0.039)	-0.021 (0.056)
Low-income	0.357 (0.019)	0.333 (0.026)	0.382 (0.028)	0.441 (0.040)	0.322 (0.038)	0.049 (0.038)	-0.119** (0.056)
First-gen	0.455 (0.020)	0.473 (0.027)	0.435 (0.028)	0.403 (0.040)	0.467 (0.041)	-0.038 (0.039)	0.065 (0.057)
White	0.567 (0.020)	0.566 (0.027)	0.569 (0.028)	0.539 (0.040)	0.599 (0.040)	0.003 (0.039)	0.060 (0.057)
Black	0.069 (0.010)	0.096 (0.016)	0.039 (0.011)	0.039 (0.016)	0.039 (0.016)	-0.057*** (0.020)	0.001 (0.022)
Asian	0.248 (0.017)	0.222 (0.023)	0.278 (0.026)	0.292 (0.037)	0.263 (0.036)	0.056 (0.034)	-0.029 (0.051)
<i>Panel B: UK region</i>							
North	0.428 (0.020)	0.413 (0.027)	0.444 (0.028)	0.461 (0.040)	0.428 (0.040)	0.031 (0.039)	-0.033 (0.057)
The Midlands	0.030 (0.007)	0.030 (0.009)	0.029 (0.010)	0.039 (0.016)	0.020 (0.011)	-0.001 (0.013)	-0.019 (0.019)
South	0.331 (0.019)	0.329 (0.026)	0.333 (0.027)	0.299 (0.037)	0.368 (0.039)	0.004 (0.037)	0.070 (0.054)
London	0.208 (0.016)	0.225 (0.023)	0.190 (0.022)	0.195 (0.032)	0.184 (0.032)	-0.035 (0.032)	-0.011 (0.045)
<i>Panel C: Academic characteristics</i>							
Taking ≥ 3 A-levels	0.850 (0.014)	0.832 (0.020)	0.869 (0.019)	0.838 (0.030)	0.901 (0.024)	0.037 (0.028)	0.064* (0.038)
Predicted tariff points	126.400 (2.066)	125.078 (2.937)	127.843 (2.901)	124.416 (4.091)	131.316 (4.110)	2.765 (4.128)	6.900 (5.799)
<i>Panel D: Baseline beliefs</i>							
Baseline social belief (Oxford)	50.734 (1.234)	50.359 (1.717)	51.144 (1.778)	51.234 (2.468)	51.053 (2.569)	0.785 (2.472)	-0.181 (3.562)
Baseline offer belief (Oxford)	25.062 (0.893)	25.719 (1.241)	24.346 (1.288)	23.766 (1.772)	24.934 (1.876)	-1.372 (1.789)	1.168 (2.581)
Baseline graduation belief (Oxford)	61.290 (1.290)	63.376 (1.804)	59.150 (1.839)	61.364 (2.685)	56.908 (2.507)	-4.225 (2.576)	-4.456 (3.673)
N	640	334	306	154	152		

Table OA7: University tiers for videos

Tier	UCAS tariff cutoff (25th percentile)	Letter grade equivalent	Restricted to A-level students?	Universities
1	144	AAA	Y	Cambridge, Imperial, LSE, Glasgow
2	128	ABB	N	Bath, Warwick, Durham, Leeds, Edinburgh
3	0	—	N	Loughborough, Newcastle, QMUL, Queen's Belfast, Nottingham, Sheffield, Southampton, York

Notes: Table indicating the university tiers used in the RCT. We report the UCAS tariff point cutoff for the tier – we include all universities whose 25th percentile tariff points for enrolled students is equal to or above this threshold in the tier – the equivalent in terms of letter grades, whether we restrict students assigned to this tier to be those taking A-levels (this is the case for tier 1), and some examples of universities in each tier.

Table OA8: Mentor Pool Summary Statistics

Characteristic	Percentage of mentors
<i>Demographics</i>	
Female	62.8
Current university student	59.0
First-gen uni attendee	42.2
Low-income	28.9
<i>Age</i>	
18–21	48.2
22–25	28.2
26+	23.7
<i>Ethnicity</i>	
White	60.0
Black	7.8
Asian	22.5
Mixed / other	9.8
<i>N</i>	245

Notes: Characteristics of participating mentors, as reported in our mentor recruiting survey.

Table OA9: Treatment arms in each wave

Wave	1 (Fall 2024)				
	2 (Spring 2025)				
Treatment arm	C	T	C	T1	T2
Workshop	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Videos		Y		Y	Y
Mentors		Y		Y	Y
Demo. matched mentors				N	Y

Notes: Table indicating which treatment components are offered to students by treatment arm. ‘Demo. matched mentors’ refer to mentors that are guaranteed to share at least one characteristic from gender, ethnicity, and UK region with the student they are matched with.

Table OA10: Timelines for each of the experimental waves

	Fall 2024	Spring 2025
School recruitment	Jul – Sep 2024	Sep 2024 – Apr 2025
Baseline surveys	Sep – Nov 2024	Jan – June 2025
In-school workshops / midline surveys	Sep – Nov 2024	Apr – June 2025
Mentorship	Oct 2024 – Jan 2025	May – Oct 2025
Endline survey	N/A	Oct 2025
University applications	Oct 2024 – Jan 2025	Oct 2025 – Jan 2026

Notes: Timing of experiment and outcomes in Fall 2024 and Spring 2025 waves.

A. Details of Treatments

Active control workshop.—We designed the workshop to provide key information about the application process. Specifically, our materials discussed how universities make admissions decisions; statistics on grades and qualifications at different universities; statistics on earnings and students’ perspectives on different universities; the application process and timeline; ‘degree apprenticeships’ and other hybrid courses including work components; student loans, cost of living and student finance; advice on students’ personal statements; suggestions about where to find more information; and a description of the mentorship and visit components of the programme. The statistics provided were the most novel component of the workshop, as other information largely mirrored easily accessible information about the application process. Appendix Figures [OA51–OA58](#) show the statistics presented. We inform students about how universities make admission decisions—including information about how they may have more lenient offer conditions for low-income students—and provide statistics about the qualifications and grades required for admission at different

universities, resulting earnings, and statistics from student surveys about their sense of belonging on their course, regret about course choice, and overall satisfaction.

Conceptually, this active control workshop ensured that all participating students had a baseline level of information about the university application process *in general*, allowing our treatments to then shock beliefs and preferences about *specific universities*. It helped to calibrate students' prior beliefs about how ability and social type might affect academic and non-academic payoffs at university by providing statistics about these outcomes, reducing variation in these priors across students. The workshops also served several logistical functions. Having a component of the programme available to all students rather than just the treatment group was important for school recruitment, as schools would have been less enthusiastic about a programme in which a large fraction of their students would get no benefit. Having a highly salient in-school component of the programme—students were taken out of their lessons to attend the workshop—substantially raised the salience of the programme and engagement with the other treatments, particularly as we instructed workshop presenters to describe and promote the mentorship and visit treatments during the workshop (see Appendix Figure [OA67](#)).

Videos.—Students in the relevant treatment groups were shown two videos towards the end of the baseline survey. Appendix Figure [OA20](#) illustrates how the videos were displayed to students in the survey. Speakers were asked to discuss: the school and city the student attended; their A-Levels / other qualifications; how they made their decisions about which universities to apply to; where they got offers from and ultimately attended; student life in their area at university; fitting in and making friends; cost of living and expenses; and teaching quality on their course. Videos provide exposure to a particular university in a manner that is more detailed and personal than generic online information, but more scalable than direct conversations online or in-person. The design of the video replicates what a student might learn in a conversation about university, but without the interactivity and potential for follow-ups of a full conversation. As illustrated in Appendix Figure [OA19](#), we introduced these videos as students describing their application process and university experience in a way that might be helpful for students; we did not imply that we were encouraging students to apply to these particular universities.

We selected videos to show students relating to universities that were aspirational but realistic given their predicted grades. Earlier in the baseline survey, we ask students to enter their predicted grades, and converted them into UCAS tariff points, a metric provided by UCAS to compare grades across different qualifications (see Appendix [OA1](#)). We then grouped universities into four tiers based on the distribution of students' grades, as recorded in the public statistics on the [discoveruni.gov.uk](https://www.discoveruni.gov.uk) website. Specifically, universities

were assigned to one of four tiers based on the 25th percentile of UCAS tariff points of enrolled students at the university. Appendix Table ?? provides the cutoffs for each tier and their A-level letter grade equivalents, as well as some examples of universities in each tier. We then assigned *students* to tiers based on their predicted tariff points, using the 25th percentile groups described in Appendix Table ?? as cutoffs. We assigned all students to at least tier 3 even if their predicted grades fell below the tier 3 cutoff, on the grounds that lower-ranked universities would have the potential to discourage ambitious applications, and only assigned students to tier 1 if they were taking A-levels and had predicted grades exceeding the cutoff, on the grounds that the most selective courses generally do not accept vocational alternatives to A-levels.

Mentors.—We recruited a set of current university students and recent graduates to act as volunteer mentors for students in the programme. The majority of these mentors signed up through STEM Ambassadors, a STEM-focused volunteering platform. Some were recruited through other channels, such as direct outreach via university partners or via AtkinsRealis, an engineering organisation that supported the programme. Table ?? describes the characteristics of the mentors taking part in the programme. The majority are current undergraduate students, but a substantial minority were older. The sample of mentors is disproportionately female, whereas our student sample is disproportionately male, but the mentor sample has similar levels of economic disadvantage compared to the RCT sample. As in our RCT sample, there is a much lower share of white students in the sample of mentors compared with the broader student population.

Students assigned to the mentorship treatment were connected with 1–2 mentors from this pool. We sent students and mentors an email to connect them, and encouraged them to get in touch to arrange a call to talk about university applications and life at university. We suggested that mentors and mentees could discuss “[mentor’s] course, life at [mentor’s university], uni life in general, and the application process”, but did not provide a script for mentors or prescribe topics, as we wanted to allow for organic conversations and to treat the topics that students chose to discuss as an outcome of interest. Mentors were asked to have at least one 15-minute call with their students, to answer any further questions over email, and to arrange follow-up calls if the student was interested and the mentor was available. Students were also able to ask questions of their mentors over email if they preferred not to have a call.

During the midline survey, and before students were informed whether they would be connected with a mentor, students were asked (a) whether they would like a mentor, and (b) to name three universities that they would be interested in receiving a mentor from. We connected each student in the relevant treatment arm with a mentor from one of these three

universities, subject to availability of a mentor in our mentor pool.⁴⁴ We also identified a second mentor from a less familiar university to connect students with, based on their university tier and the subject that they intended to apply for. In both cases, students in treatment arm T1 were matched with mentors with whom they did *not* share a gender, ethnicity, or home region of the UK, while students in arm T2 matched with mentors with whom they shared at least one of these characteristics. We describe the matching algorithm in full in Appendix Section B.

B. *Algorithm for mentor assignment*

Students are first assigned to a treatment arm T1 or T2. We assign a latent treatment arm for students in the control group, so that these students can be notionally assigned mentors according to the same procedure as treated students.

We seek to identify a tier-based and / or a preference-based mentor for each student—we target assigning each treated student one mentor of each type, but will assign only one mentor if there are no eligible mentors with remaining capacity. For preference-based mentors, we take the set of mentors from one of the three universities that the student requested. We then restrict to mentors with the appropriate demographics (different gender, ethnicity and region for students in T1; same gender, ethnicity or region for students in T2). Ethnicities are categorised into white, black, Asian, and other; regions are the 9 ITL 1 statistical regions of England. We then select the mentor with the highest capacity to take on new mentors remaining, and assign this mentor to the student. The mentor’s capacity is decremented by 1 after being assigned, starting from the number of students that they initially told us they could take on.

For tier-based mentors, we similarly restrict on demographics based on the treatment arm. We exclude any mentors from universities that the student requested a mentor from, or that they reported a parent or sibling as having attended, so that the tier-based mentor is unfamiliar. We allow for overlap with the video treatment university. We then restrict to universities in the same tier that the student was assigned to (see Table ??). Next, we try to match on students’ majors. We start by looking for a match on the exact major; if there are no available mentors within the exact major, we then use a more aggregated definition of major, and if there are still none then we take all mentors within the remaining universities. We then assign this mentor as the tier-based mentor; if there are multiple available mentors suitable to be matched, we take the mentor with the highest remaining capacity.

44. Students who responded ‘definitely not’ to the question of whether they wanted a mentor were not connected with a mentor to avoid wasting student and mentor time.

OA8. Survey Questions

A. Baseline survey

Figure OA6: Student name and school

Select your school

Enter your first name

Enter your surname

Figure OA7: Student academic year

Which school year are you currently in?

☐ Year 13

☐ Year 12

Figure OA8: Student qualifications

What qualifications are you studying for?

A-levels	☐
BTECs	☐
T-levels	☐

Figure OA9: Student predicted grades

What are your **predicted grades** in your A-level subjects?

If you are doing fewer than 4, you can select N/A for some subjects. If you don't have predicted grades yet, enter your best guess for each of your subjects.

	A-Level Predicted Grade
Subject 1	A* ▼
Subject 2	A ▼
Subject 3	B ▼
Subject 4	N/A ▼

Figure OA10: Student major choice

Which of these best represents the subject that you will apply to university for?

Agriculture, Food and Related Studies

Allied Health

Architecture, Building and Planning

Biosciences

Business and Management

Celtic Studies

Chemistry

Combined and General Studies

Computing

Creative Arts and Design

Economics

Education and Teaching

Engineering

English Studies

General, Applied and Forensic Sciences

Geography, Earth and Environmental Studies

Health and Social Care

Figure OA11: University choice

If you had to apply to five universities today, which five universities would you pick for Mathematical Sciences courses?

Choice 1:
University of Cambridge

Choice 2:
The London School of Economics and Political Science (LSE)

Choice 3:
The University of Warwick

Choice 4:
University College London (UCL)

Choice 5:
University of York

Figure OA12: University top choice

Which one of these would be your top choice to attend?

University of Cambridge ☐

The London School of Economics and Political Science (LSE) ☐

The University of Warwick ☐

University College London (UCL) ☐

University of York ☐

Figure OA13: University choice motivation (open-text)

In a few sentences, can you explain why you picked these 5 courses? What about your top choice?

Figure OA14: Admission beliefs

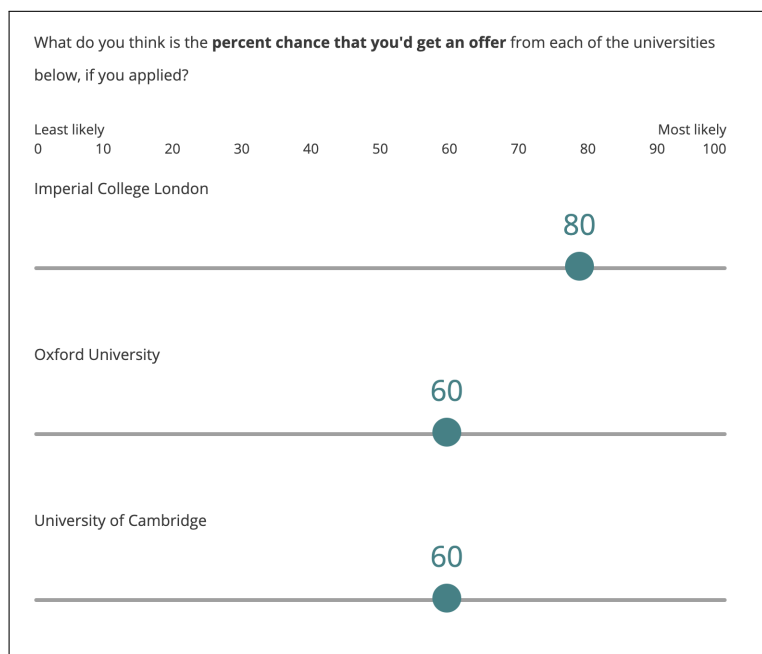


Figure OA15: Social fit beliefs

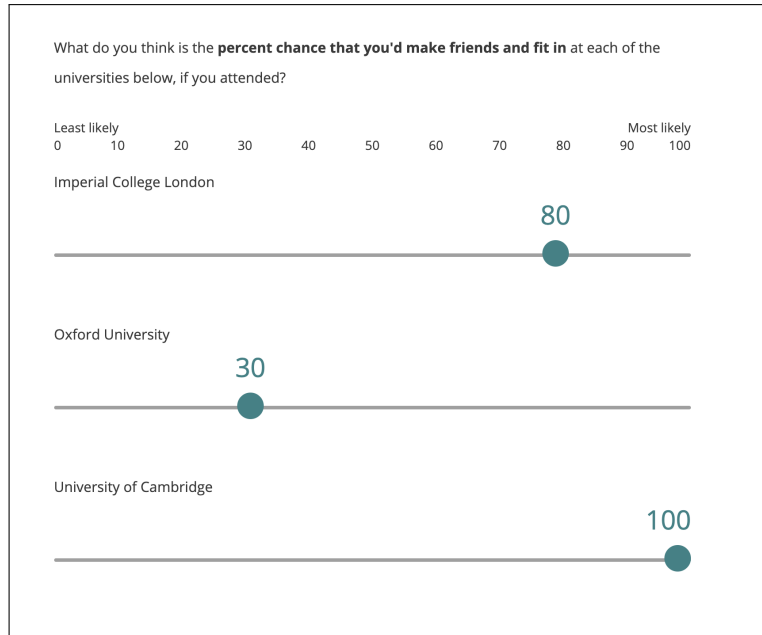


Figure OA16: Graduation beliefs

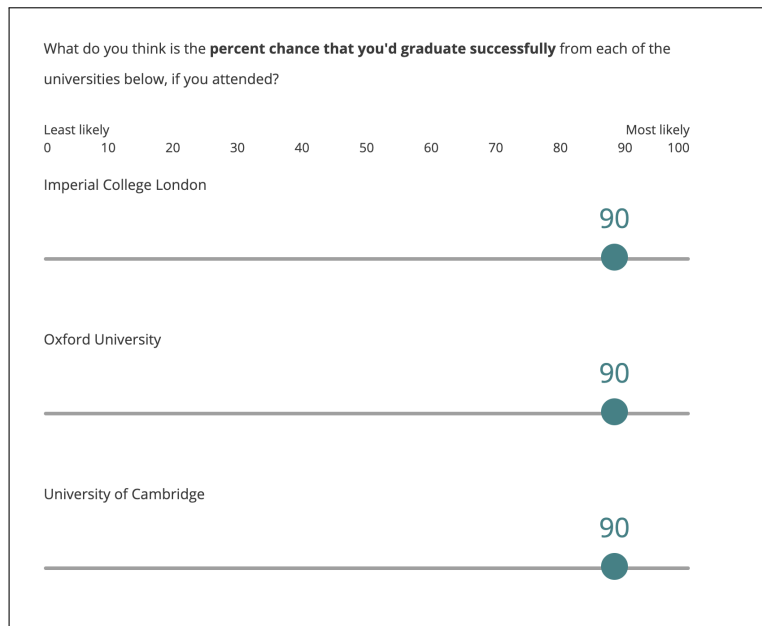


Figure OA17: Typical grades beliefs

What do you think are **typical A-level grades (e.g. ABB)** for students at each of the universities below in your subject?

Imperial College London

Oxford University

University of Cambridge

Figure OA18: Beliefs about typical university at students' school

Which university do you think **students at** [REDACTED] **most commonly attended** in the past few years?

The University of Liverpool ▼

Figure OA19: Introduction to videos

Next, you will watch two videos from current university students describing their application process and university experience. **Please watch both videos carefully.** We can tell if you watch the videos in full or not, so please try to watch both of them to the end. We hope that these videos will be helpful for your university application process!

Figure OA20: Video page

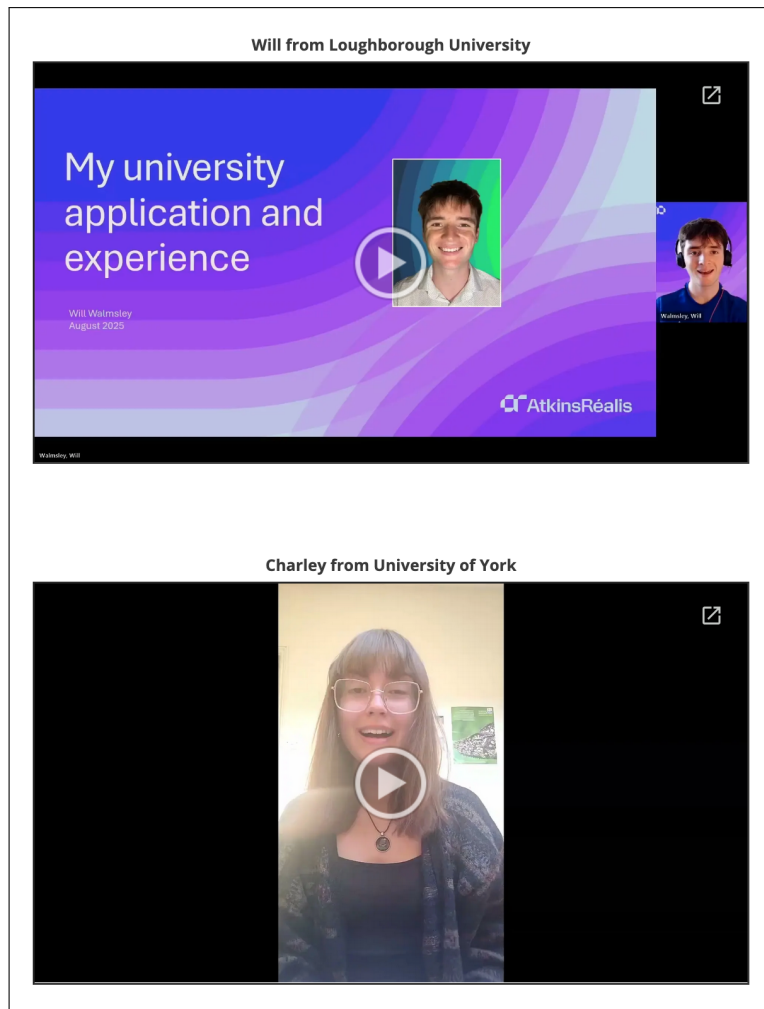


Figure OA21: Video text responses

Optional: tell us something here about what you took away from the videos. For example, were there some things that surprised you? What did you find most helpful? Least helpful? Are there any follow up questions you would like to ask the speakers?

Figure OA22: Re-elicitation of admission beliefs after video

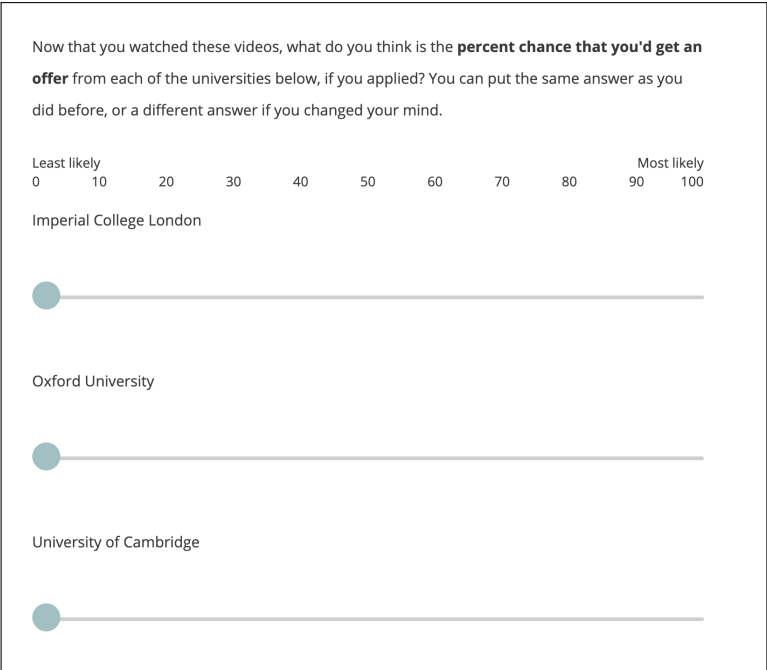


Figure OA23: Re-elicitation of social beliefs after video

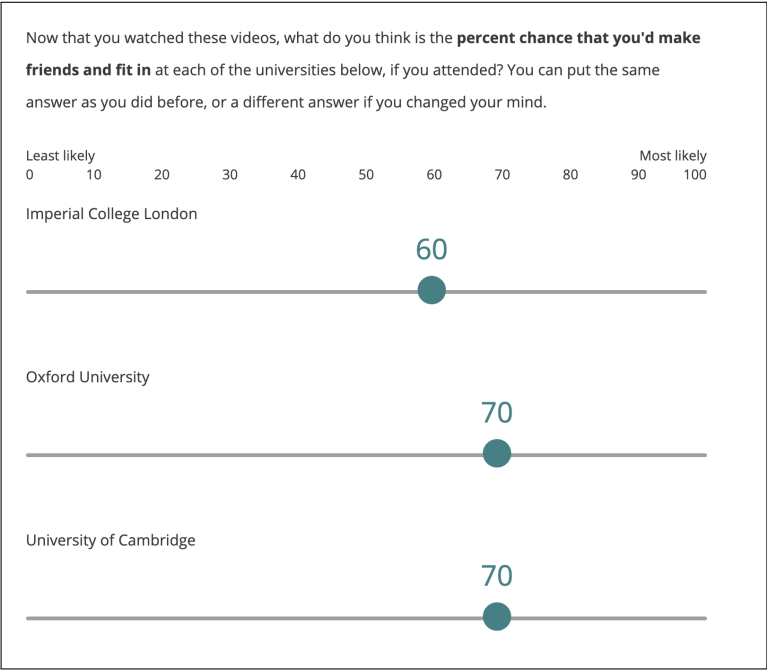


Figure OA24: Re-elicitation of graduation beliefs after video

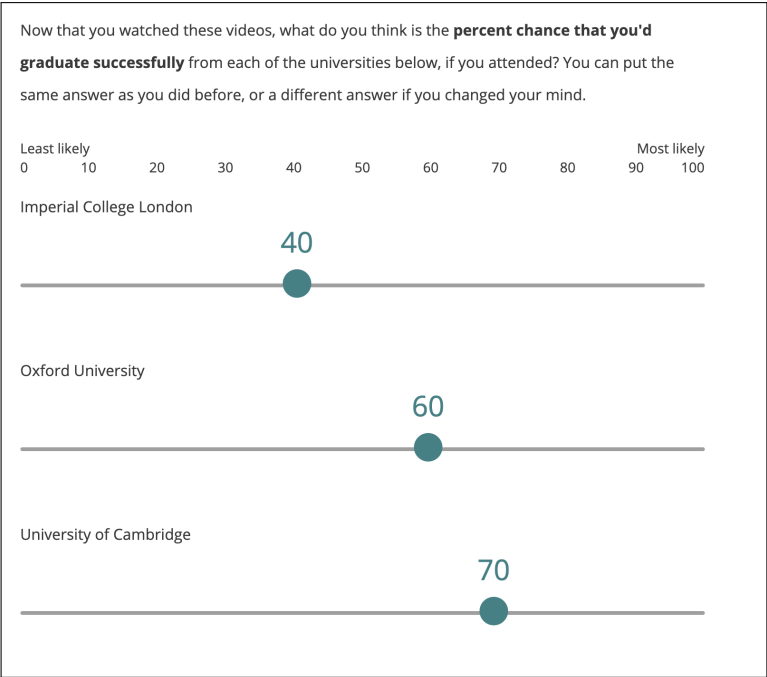


Figure OA25: End of survey message

Thanks for taking the time to answer our survey! If you have any questions, concerns, or comments please email either ntadjfar@mit.edu or kvira@mit.edu.

We hope you enjoy the workshop!

B. Midline survey

Figure OA26: Student name and school

Thank you for participating in this research! In this survey, we'll ask you questions about yourself and how you are thinking about the university application process as of today. We expect this survey to take less than 10 minutes.

You may have seen similar questions in a previous survey. Feel free to answer the same or differently. We're curious about whether or not your thought process has evolved, so there are no right answers.

Your answers to this survey are **confidential** and will only be accessible by MIT researchers Nagisa Tadjfar and Kartik Vira. **Your friends and teachers will not be able to see your responses.**

Select your school and name below.

School

Full name

Figure OA27: Student major choice

Which of these subjects are you planning on applying to university for? If you are considering applying for multiple subjects or joint courses, select the subject that you're most confident that you want to apply for. If none of these are exactly what you plan to apply for, pick the best fit from the list below.

Figure OA28: University choice

You indicated Economics as your main subject. If you had to apply to five universities today, which five universities would you pick for Economics courses?

Choice 1:

Choice 2:

Choice 3:

Choice 4:

Choice 5:

Figure OA29: University top choice

If you were guaranteed to get an offer from all five courses and meet the offer conditions, which one would be your top choice to attend?

University of Cambridge	☐
The London School of Economics and Political Science (LSE)	☐
University of York	☐
University College London (UCL)	☐
The University of Warwick	☐

Figure OA30: Family university attendees

Which of these applies to you? Select as many boxes as apply.

I have a parent or guardian who went to university	☒
I have an older sibling who went to or is currently in university	☐
I have another close relative who went to or is currently in university	☐
I have an older friend who went to or is currently in university	☐
None of the above	☐

Figure OA31: Universities attended by family members

You indicated above that you have a parent or guardian who went to university. If they went to university in the UK, please select the university(s) that they attended.

You indicated above that you have an older sibling who went to or is currently in university. If they went to university in the UK, please select the university(s) that they attended.

Figure OA32: Names of friends at school

Please list the full names of 3 friends you talk to regularly at your school.

	First name	Surname
Friend 1		
Friend 2		
Friend 3		

Figure OA33: A-level subjects and predicted grades

What are the subjects that you're taking and your predicted grades in each one? Enter up to 4 subjects below.

	Qualification (e.g. A-level)	Subject title (e.g. History)	Predicted grade
Subject 1			
Subject 2			
Subject 3			
Subject 4			

Figure OA34: Ethnicity

What best describes your ethnic origin?

☐ White

☐ Black/African/Caribbean

☐ Asian (Indian, Pakistani, Bangladeshi, Chinese, any other Asian background)

☐ Mixed two or more ethnic groups

☐ Other (Arab or any others)

☐ Prefer not to say

Figure OA35: Gender

What is your gender?

☐ Male

☐ Female

☐ Non-binary

☐ Prefer not to say

Figure OA36: Student home postcode

What is your home postcode?

Figure OA37: Interest in mentorship

After this workshop, many of you will be matched with current university student mentors who can answer any university-related questions you might have. Please let us know about your preferences for mentors in the questions below.

Would you be interested in being given a mentor?

Yes, definitely ☐

Yes, probably ☐

Maybe ☐

Probably not ☐

Definitely not ☐

Figure OA38: Mentor preferences

What would be your **top** choice of university to get connected to a current student from?

What would be your **second** choice of university to get connected to a current student from?

What would be your **third** choice of university to get connected to a current student from?

Figure OA39: Mentor preference explanation

In a few sentences, can you explain how you picked these 3 universities to receive mentors?

Figure OA40: Number of universities visited previously

Have you visited any universities in-person (e.g. for Open Days)?

Yes, I visited multiple universities

Yes, I visited one university

No, but I plan on visiting universities before I apply

No, I have not visited any universities and do not plan on visiting any

Figure OA41: Obstacles to university visits

Have any of the factors below stopped you from visiting a university that you are interested in?

I already know which university I want to go to

I don't think visiting the university is helpful

It would cost too much money

It would take too long to travel there and back

I didn't know it was an option / hadn't thought about it

Other

None of the above

Figure OA42: Names of universities visited

Which universities have you visited?

Figure OA43: Request for university to visit

As part of this programme, **many of you will receive up to £75 in travel funding to visit a university** of your choice in person. Which university would you like to visit using these funds?
You will only be reimbursed to visit this particular university, so please choose carefully.

Figure OA44: Admission beliefs

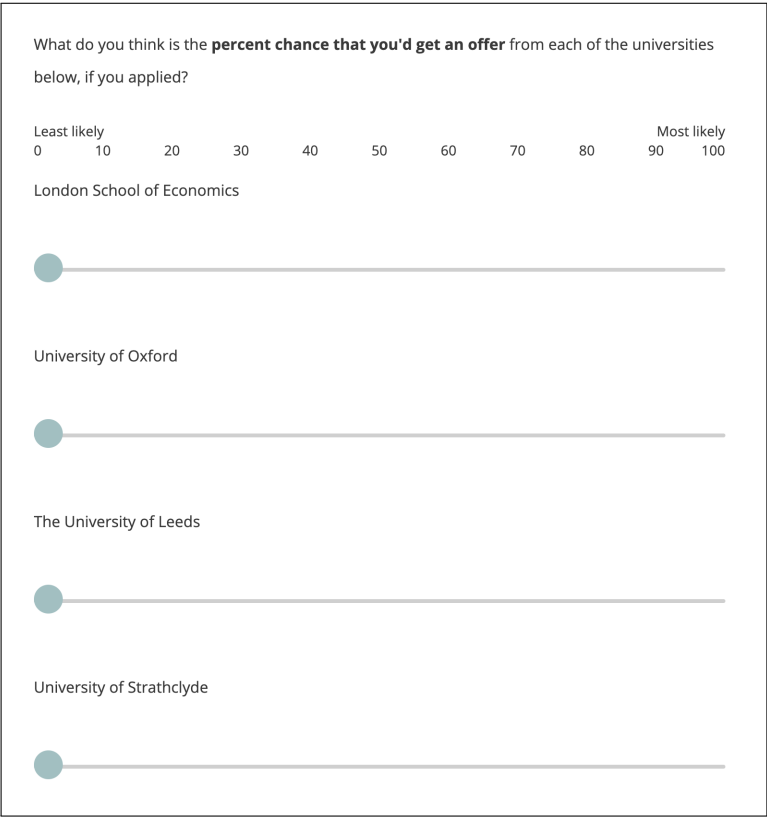


Figure OA45: Social fit beliefs



Figure OA46: Graduation beliefs



Figure OA47: Typical grades beliefs

What do you think are **typical A-level grades (e.g. ABB)** for students at each of the universities below in your subject?

London School of Economics

University of Oxford

The University of Leeds

University of Strathclyde

University	Typical A-level grades (e.g. ABB)
London School of Economics	
University of Oxford	
The University of Leeds	
University of Strathclyde	

Figure OA48: Ending screen

Congratulations! You are eligible to be matched with up to two mentors after this workshop.

Kartik Vira (kvira@mit.edu) or Nagisa Tadjfar (ntadjfar@mit.edu) from the MIT research team will reach out to you to put you in touch with your mentor(s). We'll contact you over email and over text using the details that you provided, so watch out for messages from us.

Mentors have generously volunteered their time to help you with the university process, and have a lot of useful information that should help you feel more comfortable with the application process and life at uni, so please make sure to reply to your mentors once we put you in touch with them!

Thanks for participating in this workshop - we hope you found it useful and that it'll help with your university decisions. Good luck!

OA9. Experimental materials

We present a selection of the key slides from the workshop, excluding some transition slides and slides that were less relevant to university application decisions.

Figure OA49: Presenter introduction

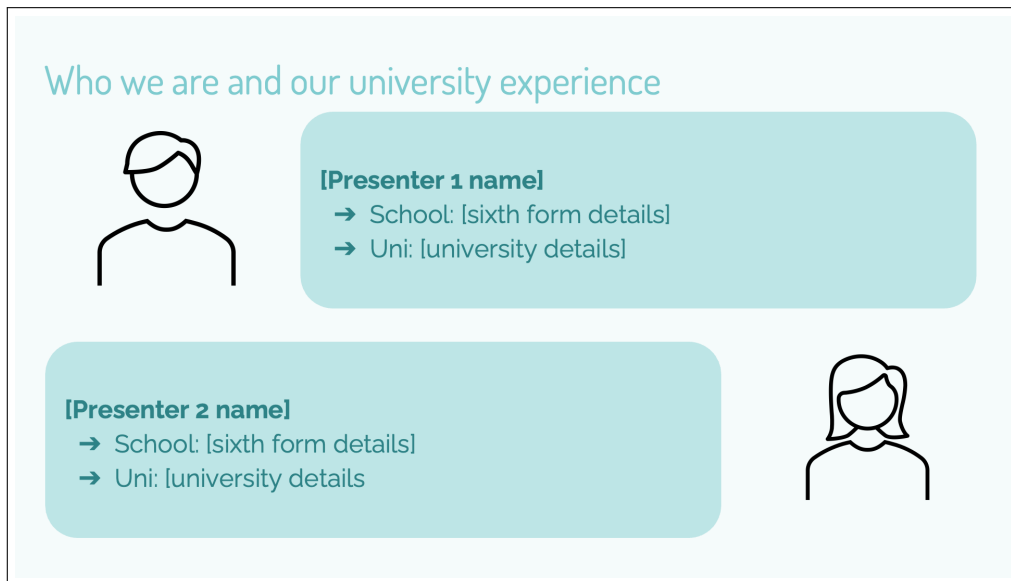


Figure OA50: Application timeline

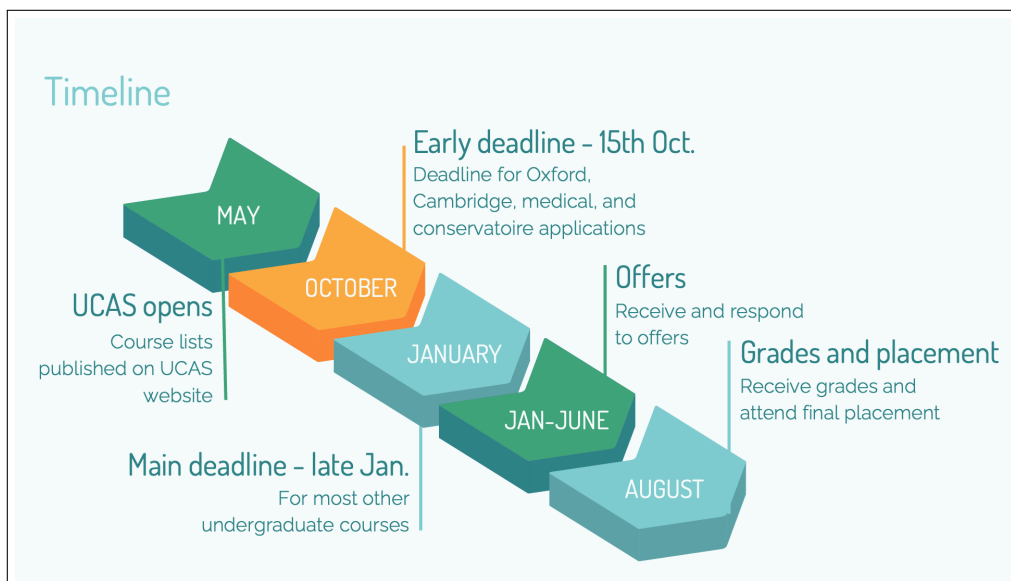


Figure OA51: How universities make admissions decisions

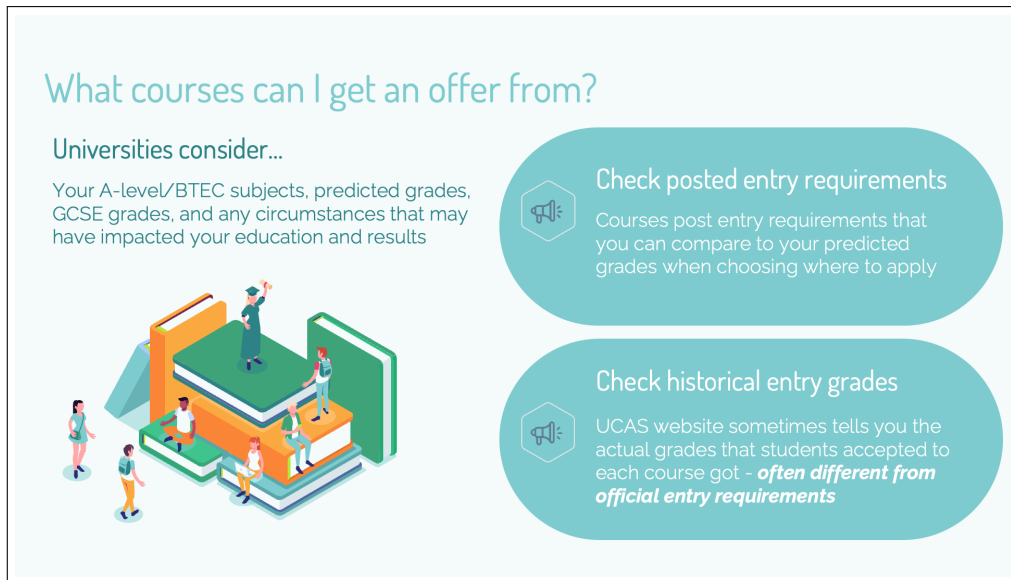


Figure OA52: Contextual admissions

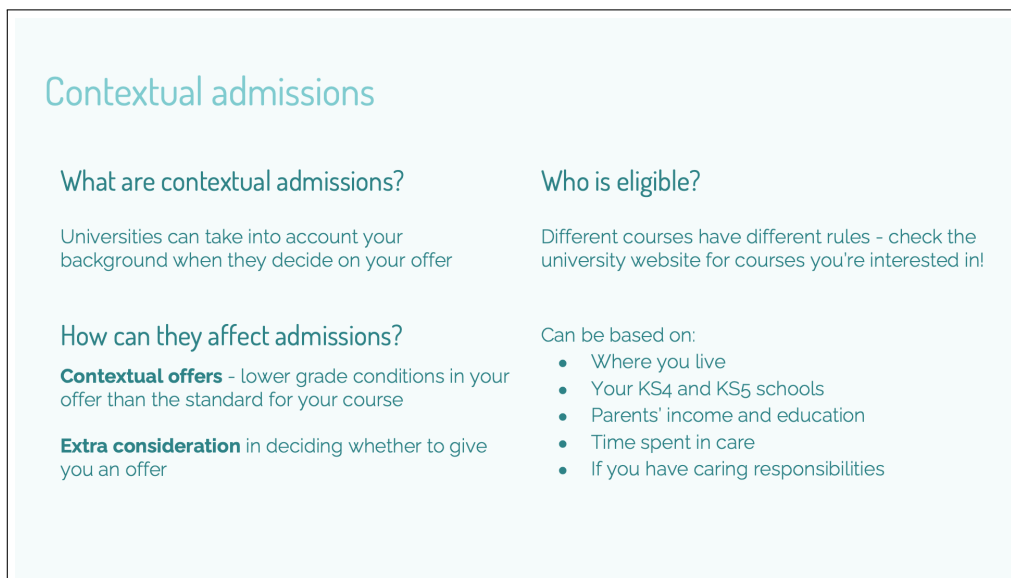


Figure OA53: Russell Group student qualifications

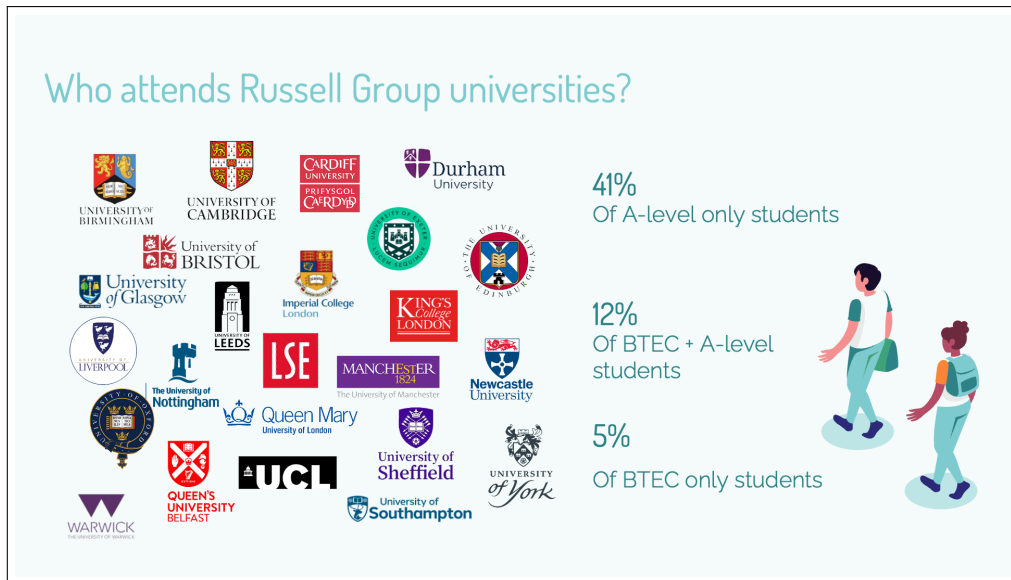


Figure OA54: Russell Group student grades

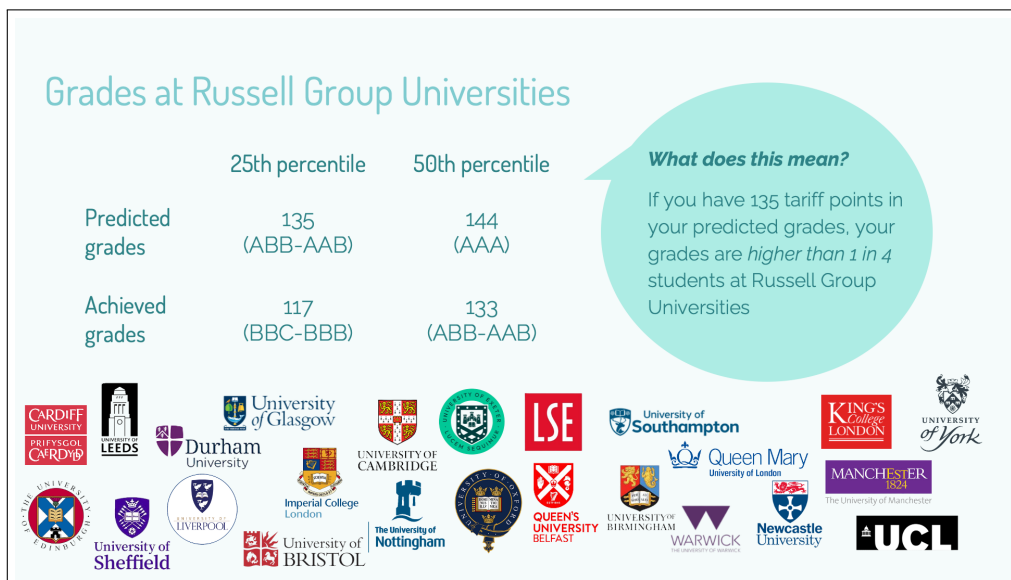


Figure OA55: Required grades at different universities

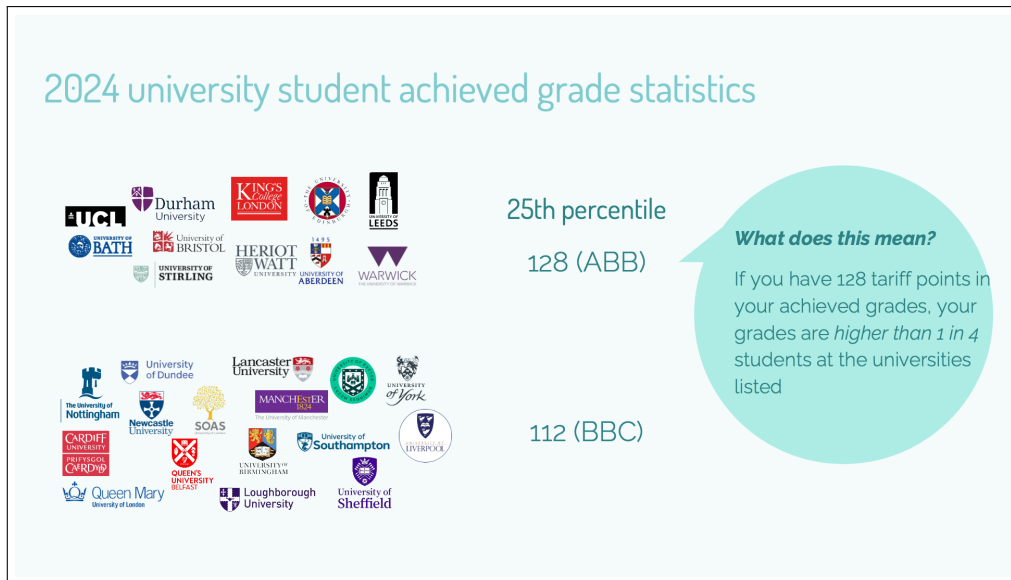


Figure OA56: Earnings at different universities



Figure OA57: Student regret statistics

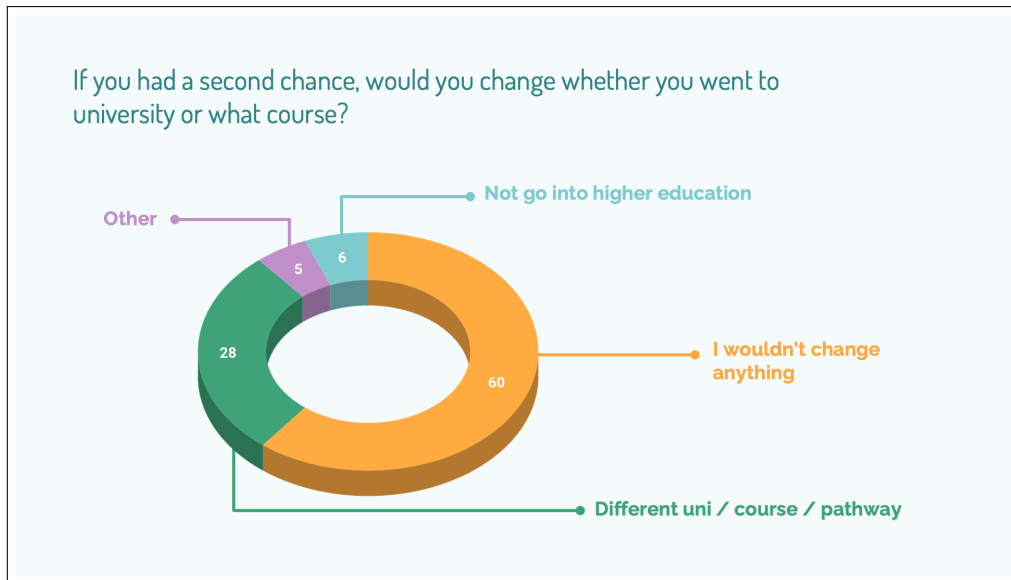


Figure OA58: Student belonging and course statistics

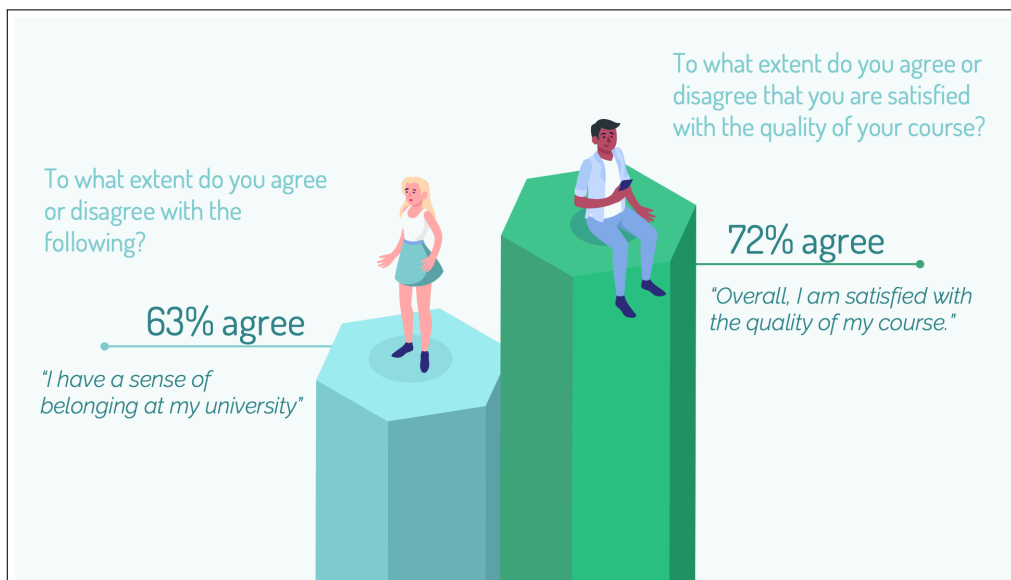


Figure OA59: Responding to offers

Responding to your offers

You may still need to meet offer conditions for your insurance, so **choose a course with lower offer conditions** than your firm!



Firm

- where you'll go if you meet the conditions in your offer
- choose this as long as you have *at least one offer*

Insurance

- can consider you if you *miss your firm conditions* and your firm doesn't accept you
- choose this if your firm choice gave you a conditional offer

Figure OA60: Tuition and cost of living

Fees and cost of living

Tuition fees

£9,535 / year at almost all UK universities - fully covered by student loans

Part-time work

55% of students did some part-time work during term time in 2023



Maintenance loans

Maintenance loans can support cost of living - up to £14,000 / year depending on where you live at uni and your parents' income

University support

Universities have hardship funds and might also provide discounts for food, travel etc. as well as affordable housing options. Be sure to ask universities *explicitly* about these as they may not be advertised!

Figure OA61: Personal statement format

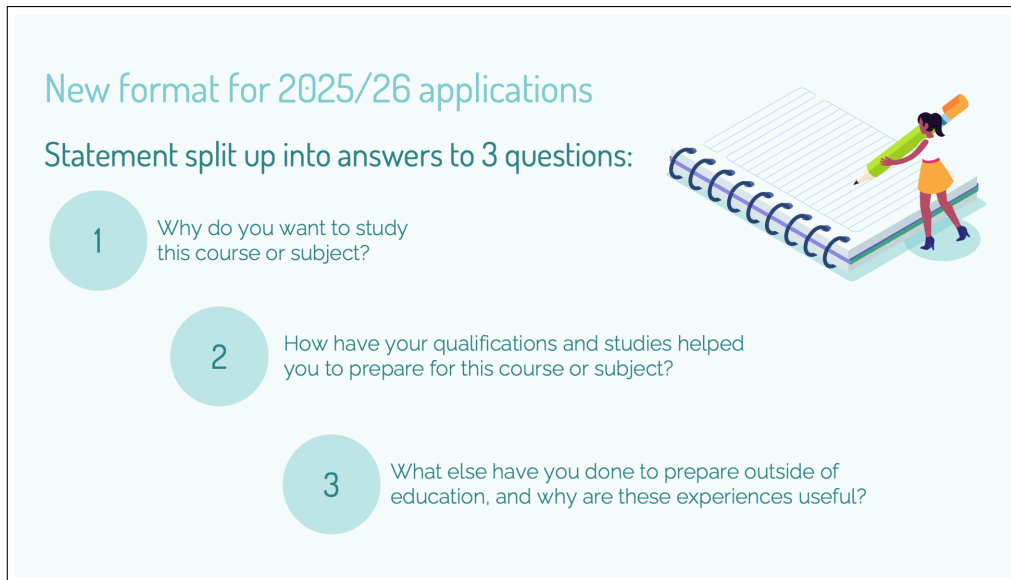


Figure OA62: Personal statement advice – what not to do

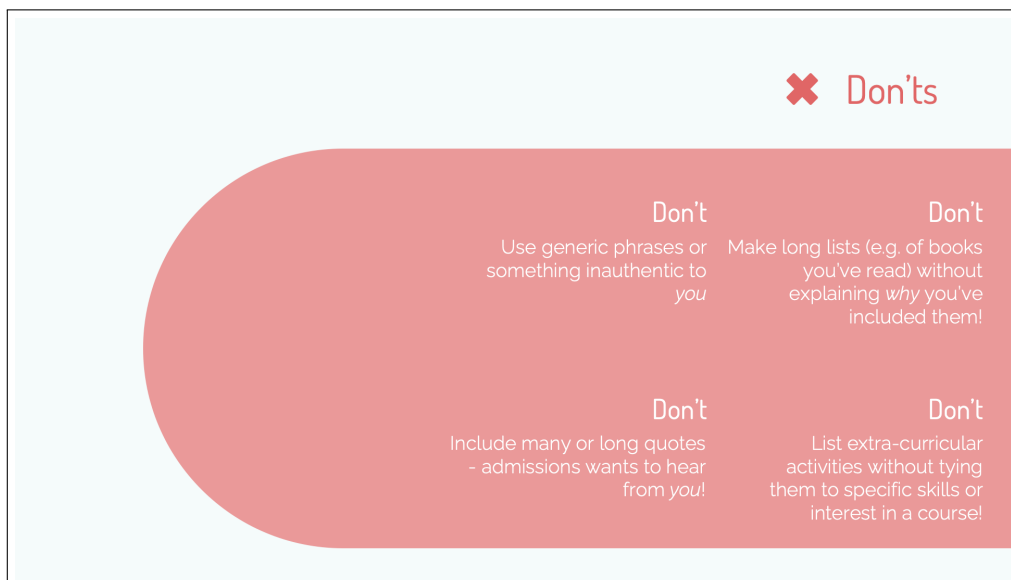


Figure OA63: Personal statement advice – what to do

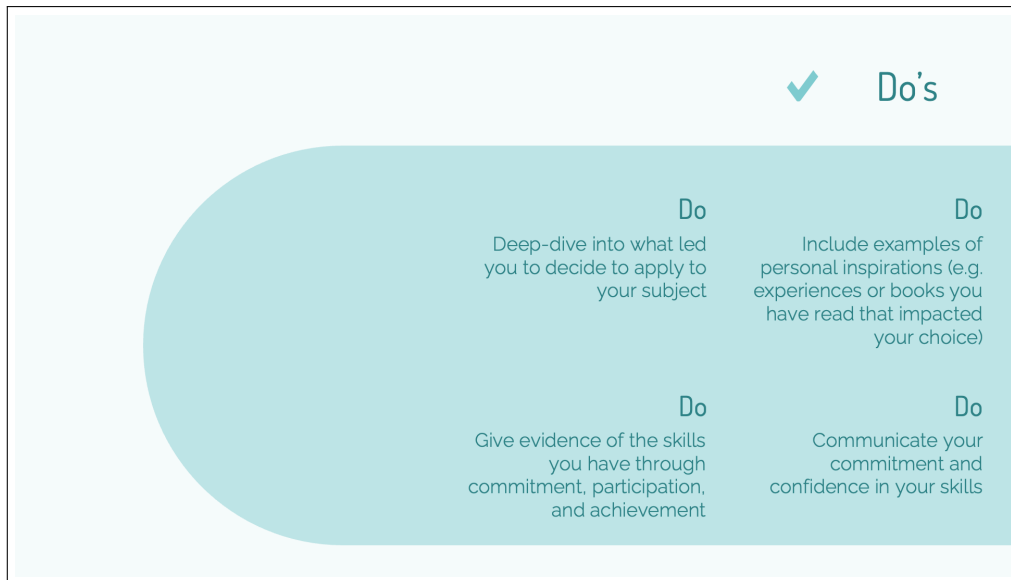


Figure OA64: Online resources

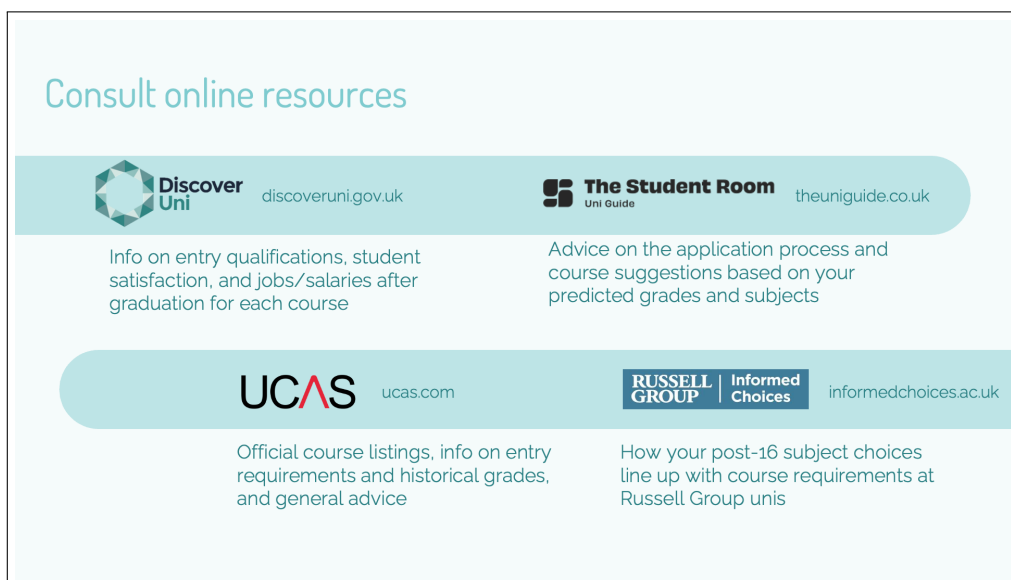


Figure OA65: Other sources of information

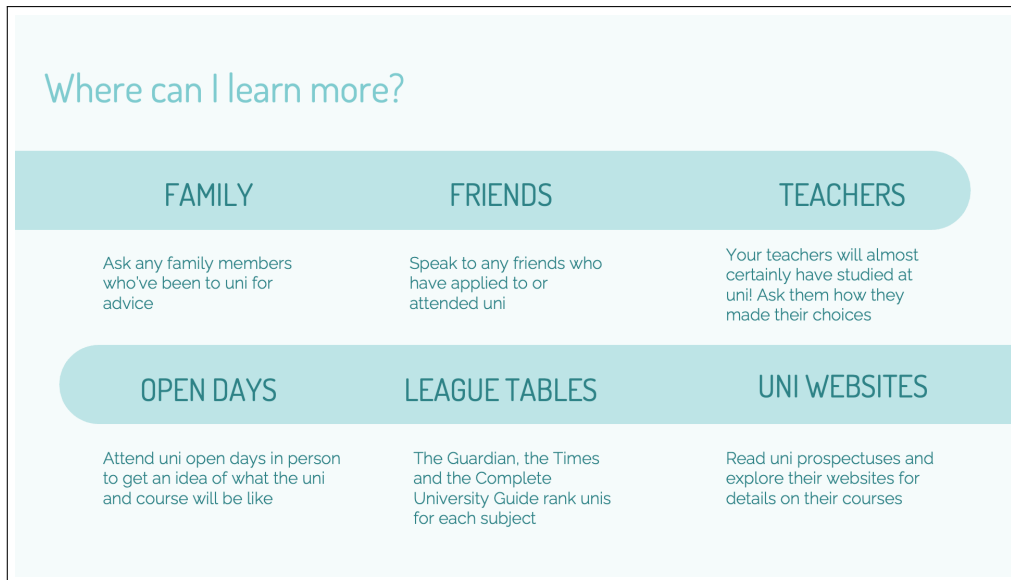


Figure OA66: University visits



Figure OA67: Description of mentorship / visit treatments

As part of this study, many of you will have the chance to...



Receive 2 mentors who are current uni students

- ◆ You can use these conversations to **learn more about unis you are curious about** (but might not know much about)
- ◆ Get **advice / tips on your application**, personal statements, etc.

Subsidised visits to universities

Receive financial support of **up to £75** to visit a university of your choice in person



Figure OA68: Survey QR code

Survey #2: tell us about your plans and preferences for mentors!



